Economy

Kicking and screaming: Child care costs persist

20 October 2026

Key takeaways

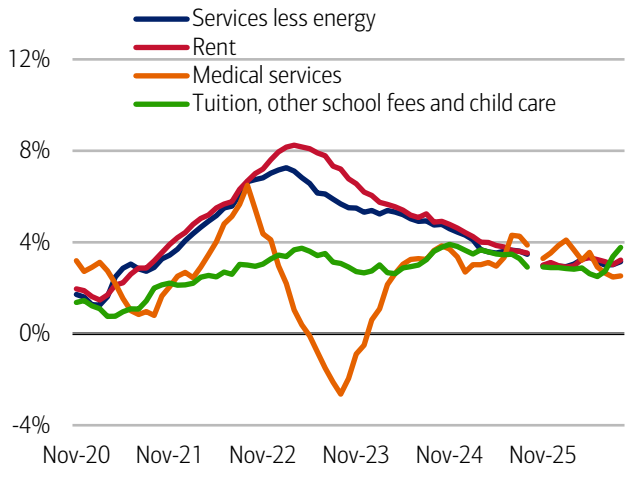
- Child care remains a growing financial burden for many households, even as growth in the median payment has moderated, according to Bank of America payments data. More families are paying more than $2,000 per month for care, suggesting affordability pressures are becoming increasingly concentrated among households facing the highest expenses.
- Child care cost pressures vary significantly across the country. Nashville and Jacksonville, FL posted the fastest year-over-year growth among major metro areas, while New York and Washington DC saw the biggest decrease in median payment growth, according to Bank of America payments data.
- Limited supply may continue to constrain access to child care for some households. Child care employment fell 0.7% year-over-year in September, suggesting provider capacity remains under pressure and could continue to affect household finances and labor force participation.

Child care costs outpace rent and medical services

Child care remains a significant expense for many families. In September, the growth in child care and other school-related fees surpassed other major household expenses such as rent and medical services, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) (Exhibit 1).

Yet, while child care prices continue to rise in official inflation data, median household payments have largely moderated since February, according to Bank of America data (Exhibit 2). More importantly, the growth in the number of households paying for child care has fallen since the start of 2025.

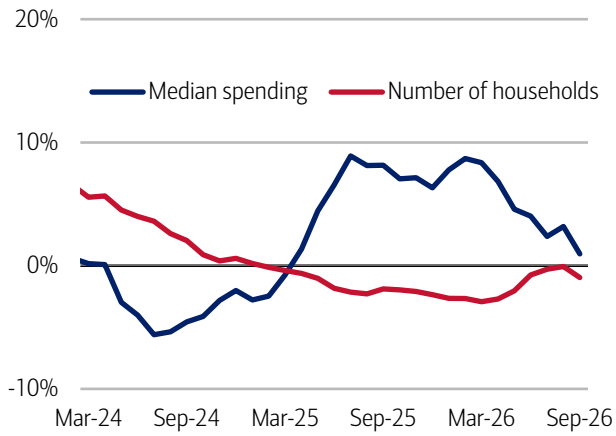
Exhibit 1: The cost of child care has surpassed other services such as rent in the consumer price index
Consumer price index by category (monthly, seasonally adjusted, YoY%)



Source: Haver Analytics

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Exhibit 2: The median child care payment per household was up 1.0% year-over-year (YoY) in September but the number of households paying for child care fell 1.0% YoY
Median child care payment per household and number of households (monthly, three-month moving average, YoY%)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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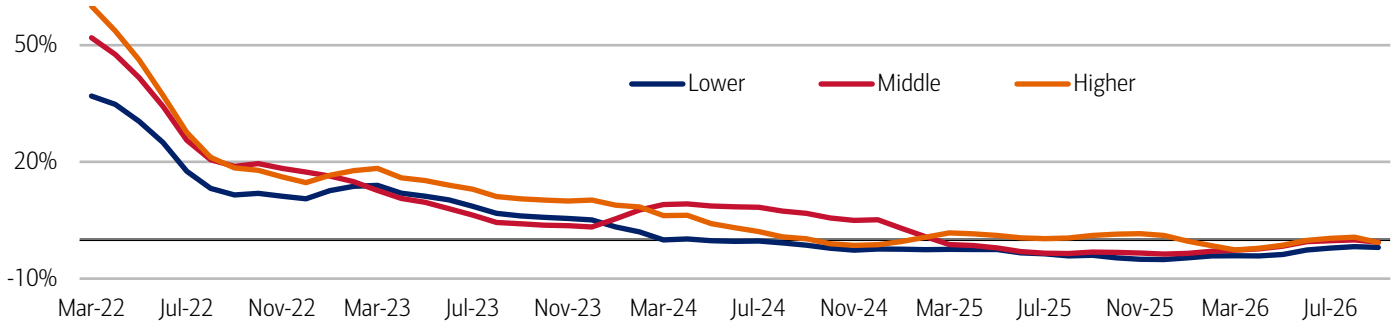
Fewer lower-income households are paying for child care

Why is Bank of America payment growth trending in the opposite direction of the Consumer Price Index? Households are likely changing the amount of care they use, which is reflected in slower growth in the number paying for child care. As more

households shift into lower-cost care (school-age, public pre-K, subsidized or free after-school programs), median payments can fall even as prices continue rising.

The decline in the number of households paying for child care may also reflect families seeking alternatives to formal care arrangements. Some may be relying more heavily on relatives, shifting parents' work schedules or dropping out of the workforce altogether to care for their children in response to elevated costs. This could explain why, among all income groups paying for care, the number of lower-income households has seen the biggest decline, falling 2.0% year-over-year (YoY) in September (Exhibit 3).

Exhibit 3: The number of lower-income households paying for child care has fallen the most, down 2.0% YoY in September
Number of households with child care payments (monthly, three-month moving average, YoY%)



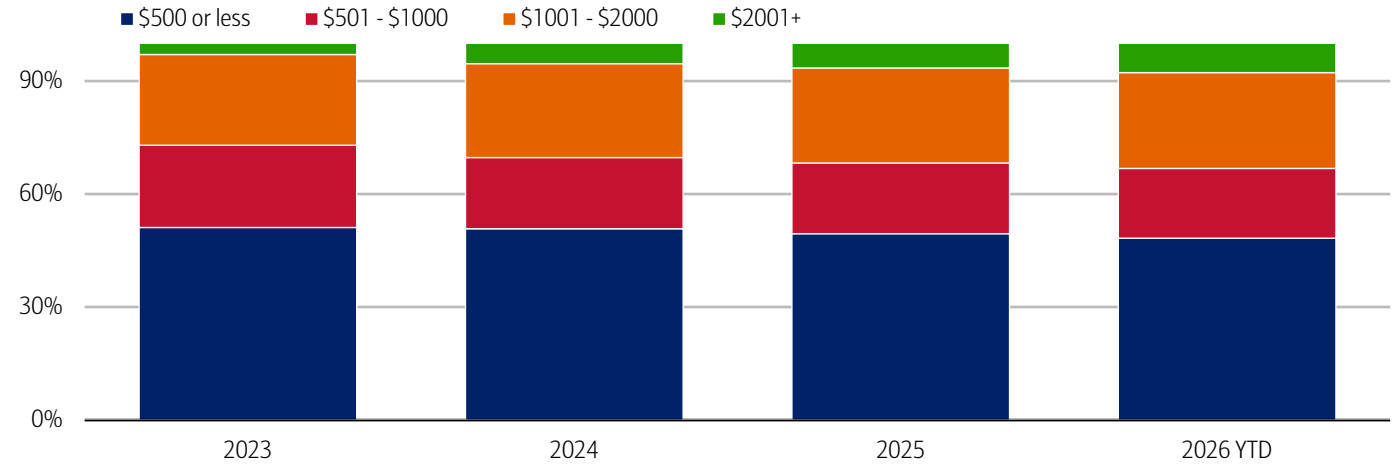
Source: Bank of America internal data

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More families face larger monthly bills

Yet even as fewer households pay for child care, the share of those shelling out more than $2,000 per month has increased substantially (Exhibit 4). In fact, it has more than doubled since 2023, reaching 7.7% in 2026 year-to-date. Meanwhile, the share of those paying $1,000 or less has declined, suggesting higher monthly payments are becoming more common even as the national median grows more slowly.

Exhibit 4: The share of households paying >$2000 a month for child care has more than doubled since 2023
Monthly child care payments by amount (annual average, share of households, %)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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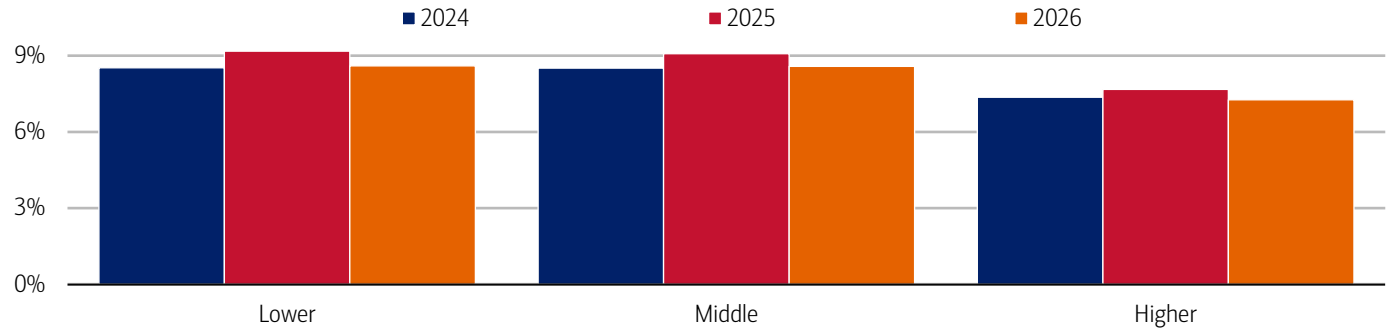
Rising costs take a bigger bite out of households' paychecks

What makes child care "affordable"? According to the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, child care is considered affordable if it accounts for no more than 7% of family income. Yet, in Bank of America data, the average child care cost was 8% in September.

While an 8% share may not appear dramatically above the federal affordability benchmark of 7%, it represents an average across households' income levels. For families in high-cost metro areas or those paying more than $2,000 per month, the burden is likely considerably higher.

Notably, lower- and middle-income households see outsized shares of their pay dedicated to child care in Bank of America payments data, though this has moderated slightly from 2025 (Exhibit 5).

Exhibit 5: In September, the average child care payment was 8.6% of lower- and middle-income total households' pay, whereas for higher-income families it accounted for 7.3%
Average child care payment as a share of pay in September by income (annual, %)



Source: Bank of America internal data

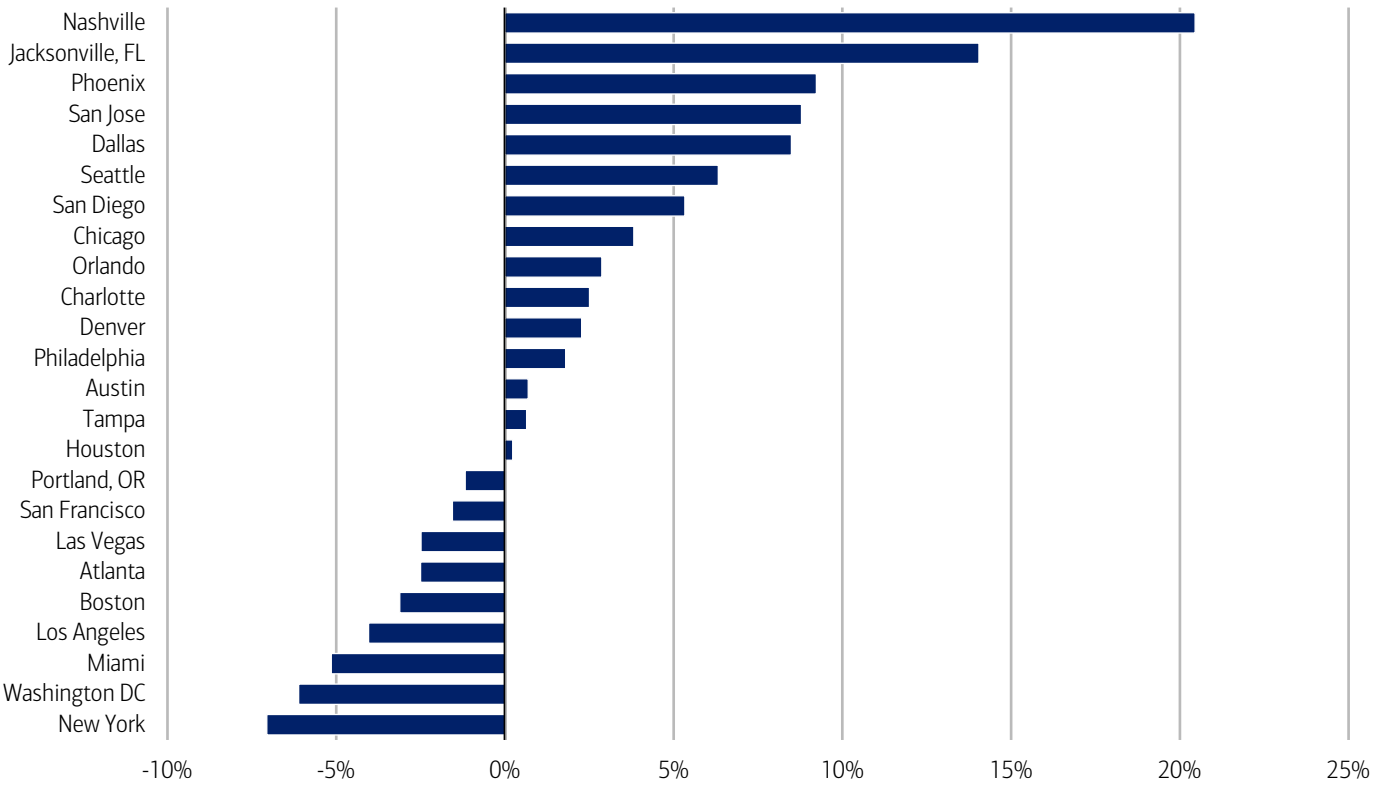
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Where child care costs are climbing

Child care pressures also differ substantially by location. In Bank of America payments data, Nashville posted the fastest YoY median payment growth in September, followed by Jacksonville, FL and Phoenix (Exhibit 6). This dispersion of growth across the country suggests child care cost pressures are no longer confined to historically expensive coastal markets.

Interestingly, New York and Washington DC saw the sharpest decline in growth this year. Why might this be? The supply side of the market may help explain why – for example, New York City recently introduced universal Pre-K.[1]

Exhibit 6: Nashville and Jacksonville, FL saw the greatest increase in median child care payment growth among select cities in September
Median child care payments by core-based statistical area in September (YoY%)



Source: Bank of America internal data

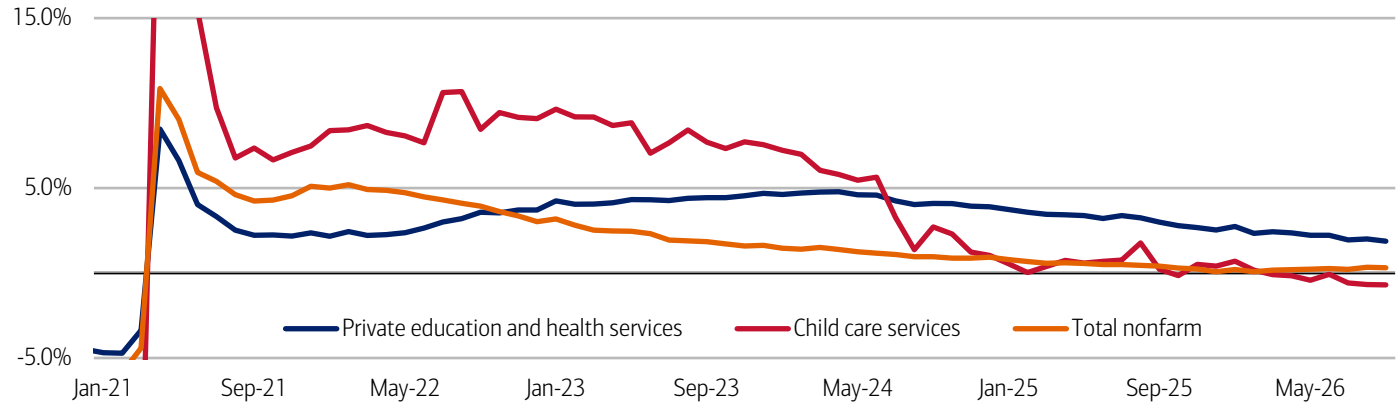
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[1] NYC Public Schools. 2026. Pre-K. New York City Department of Education.

Fewer providers, higher costs

As of September 2026, employment in child care services was down 0.7% from a year earlier, suggesting the sector's workforce recovery has stalled. Fewer workers can constrain the number of available places or the hours providers offer. That may leave families facing longer searches, fewer workable arrangements or continued price pressure. In turn, access to care can influence parents' ability to enter, remain in or expand their participation in the workforce.

Exhibit 7: Employment within child care services fell 0.7% YoY in September
Employees by sector (monthly, seasonally adjusted, YoY%)



Source: Haver Analytics

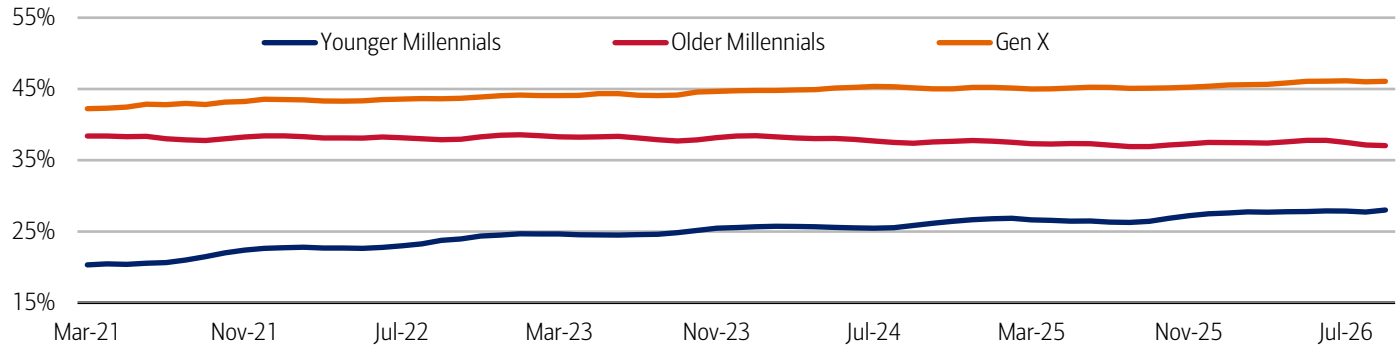
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What are the economic implications of rising child care costs?

Child care costs may have important labor market implications for families with young children. Of those households paying for child care in 2026, more than half of them were Older Millennials (52%), followed by Younger Millennials (20%) and Gen X (16%), according to Bank of America payments data. This means child care costs weigh more heavily on Older Millennials.

The share of Older Millennial households receiving more than one paycheck has continued to grow from a year earlier, but the pace of that improvement has moderated over the past three months (Exhibit 8). Given that this group accounts for the majority of households paying for child care in Bank of America payments data, they may offer early signs of how affordability affects their employment decisions.

Exhibit 8: The share of Older Millennial households paying for child care that have more than one person with a paycheck has declined since 2021
Share of households with a child care payment with more than one person with a paycheck (%, monthly, three-month moving average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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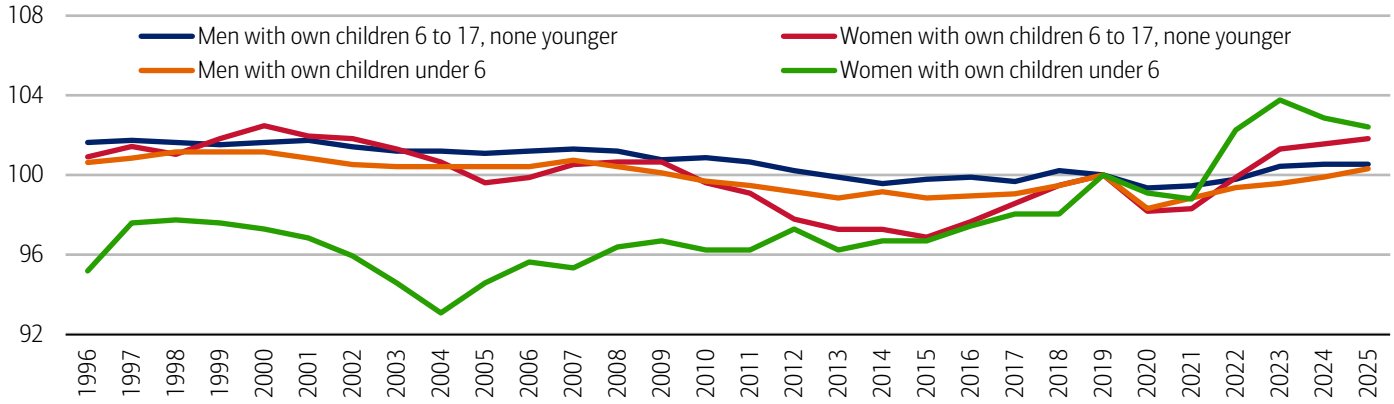
Child care challenges can weigh on women's employment

According to data from the American Time Use Survey, women continue to perform significantly more child care and household work than men, even as their participation in paid work has increased. This suggests that persistent gaps in access and affordability may have disproportionate consequences for women's employment. Indeed, the percentage of women who cited child care as a reason for temporary unemployment was nearly three times higher than men's in 2026, though the average fell from 2025, according to data from the BLS.

Yet labor force participation data indicates a more nuanced picture. Despite persistent child care pressures, mothers are participating in the workforce at rates that remain above their 2019 averages.

The strongest gains have occurred among women with children under age six, whose labor force participation rate remains well above pre-pandemic levels (Exhibit 9). Women with school-age children have also seen participation rise relative to 2019, though by a smaller margin.

Exhibit 9: In 2025, women with children under age six saw the greatest increase in their participation rate compared to the 2019 average
Annual estimates for labor force participation rates by sex and age of children (annual averages, indexed, 2019 average = 100)



Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics

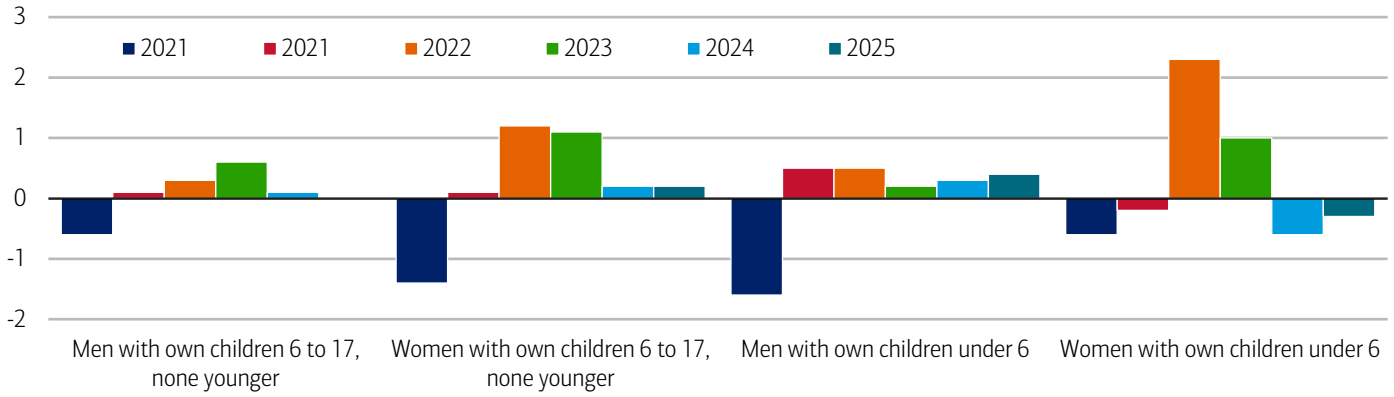
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Mothers' workforce participation remains elevated, but recent gains have slowed

However, recent momentum has slowed. While mothers of young children experienced particularly large participation gains in 2022 and 2023, those have partially reversed in 2024 and 2025 (Exhibit 10).

In contrast, participation among women with children ages 6 to 17 has continued to edge higher. This signals that the post-pandemic increase in working has largely been sustained in this group, but the pace of improvement has moderated, especially for women caring for younger children.

Exhibit 10: The labor force participation rate for women with children under age six fell in 2025 from the prior year
Annual estimates for labor force participation rates by sex and age of children (annual averages, percentage point difference from prior year)



Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics

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Methodology

Selected Bank of America transaction data is used to inform the macroeconomic views expressed in this report and should be considered in the context of other economic indicators and publicly available information. In certain instances, the data may provide directional and/or predictive value. The data used is not comprehensive; it is based on **aggregated and anonymized** selections of Bank of America data and may reflect a degree of selection bias and limitations on the data available.

Bank of America credit/debit card spending per household includes spending from active US households only. Only consumer card holders making a minimum of five transactions a month are included in the dataset. Spending from corporate cards is excluded. Data regarding merchants who receive payments are identified and classified by the Merchant Categorization Code (MCC) defined by financial services companies. The data are mapped using proprietary methods from the MCCs to the North American Industry Classification System (NAICS), which is also used by the Census Bureau, in order to classify spending data by subsector. Spending data may also be classified by other proprietary methods not using MCCs.

If applicable, the consumer deposit data based on Bank of America internal data is derived by anonymizing and aggregating data from Bank of America consumer deposit accounts in the US and analyzing that data at a highly aggregated level.

If applicable, any payments data represents aggregated spend from US Retail, Preferred, Small Business and Wealth Management clients with a deposit account or credit card. Any reference to aggregated spend include total credit card, debit card, ACH, wires, bill pay, business/peer-to-peer, cash and checks.

Unless otherwise stated, data is not adjusted for seasonality, processing days or portfolio changes, and may be subject to periodic revisions.

Additional information about the methodology used to aggregate the data is available upon request.

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Sources

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Disclosures

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Economy

Insurance costs hit the brakes

16 October 2026

Key takeaways

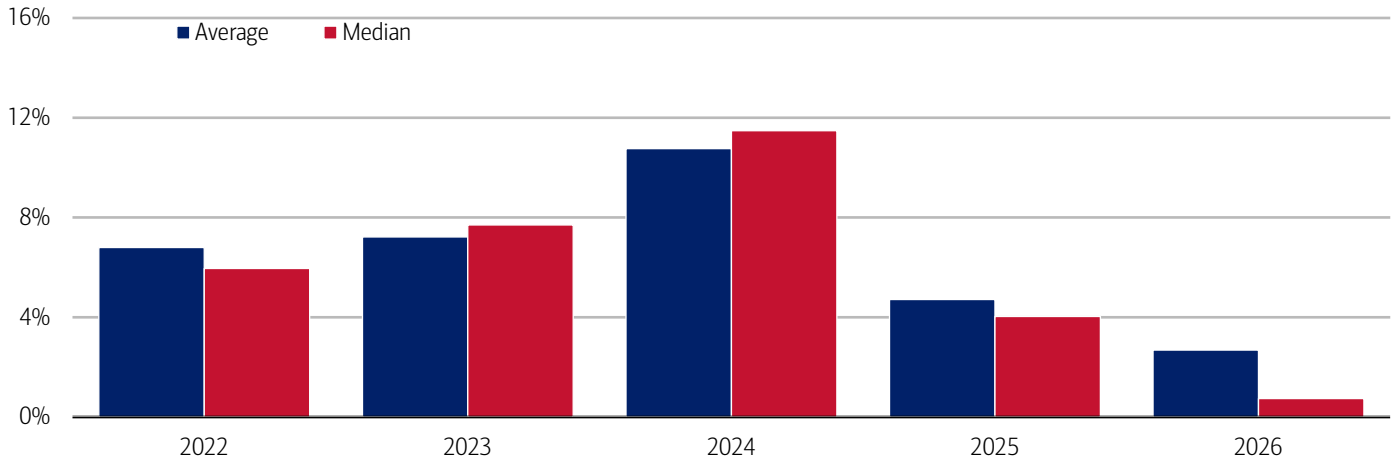
- Property insurance (e.g., auto, homeowners, renters) payment growth has slowed considerably, according to Bank of America payments data. Median payments rose just 1% year-over-year (YoY) in 2026, easing further from the 6% growth seen in 2025, after a roughly 12% increase in 2024, suggesting that many consumers are getting some relief from rising insurance payments.
- However, the moderation is uneven across consumers. Bank of America payments data suggests that Gen Z continues to experience insurance payment growth of nearly 6%, while increases for other generations are closer to 1% to 2%. Payments also rose nearly 1.5% for higher-income households but edged lower for those with lower incomes.
- Lower accident rates, easing vehicle prices, and softer major-purchase growth may be reducing cost pressures, but geography remains a major dividing line. Florida metros recorded declines of roughly 7% to 8%, while California and several Northeastern metros continued to see relatively strong increases.

Insurance payments stabilize after years of painful growth

The burden of higher property (e.g., auto, renters, homeowners) insurance payments may be easing for some. Notably, while the average payment increased 3% year-over-year (YoY), the median payment was only up 1%, according to Bank of America payments data. This suggests that most consumers have only seen a small increase in their premiums, though there may be a few outliers (Exhibit 1).

The latest data stands in contrast to just two years ago in 2024, when most consumers saw their insurance payments surge about 12% YoY, after a nearly 8% YoY increase in 2023.

Exhibit 1: Insurance payments have increased only modestly through August of this year, with growth peaking in 2024
Median and average insurance payments (September to August yearly, YoY%)

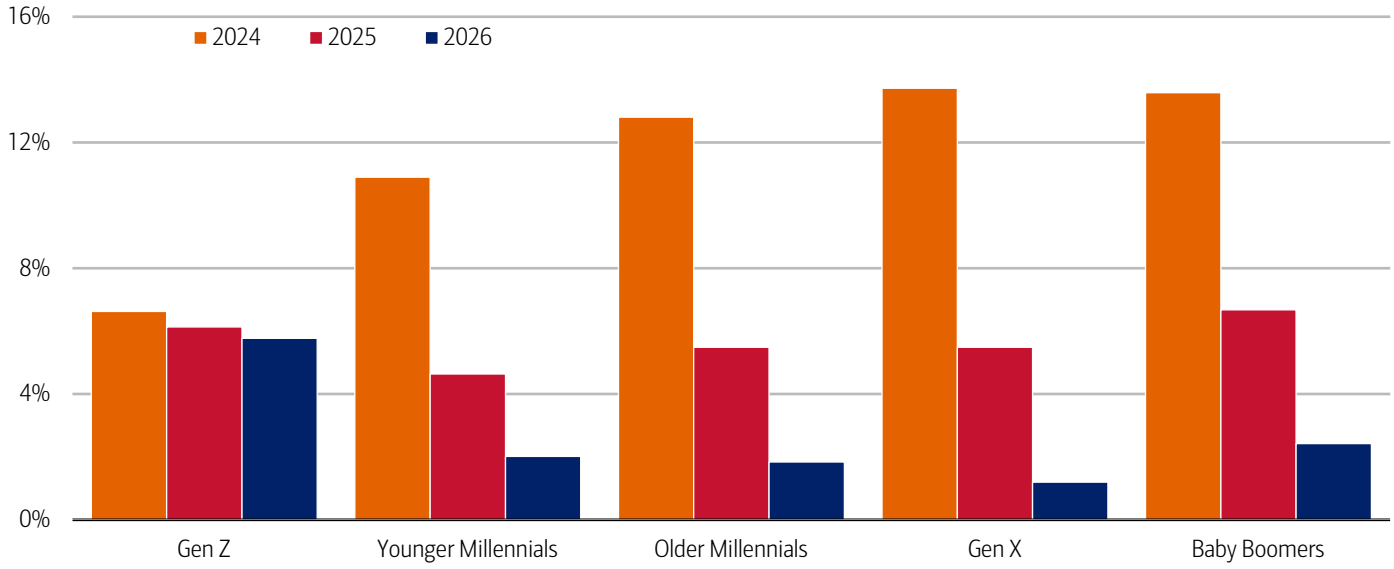


Source: Bank of America internal data

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Insurance payments by age show a similar pattern, with much stronger growth in 2024 across most generations followed by a cooling since then (Exhibit 2). Gen Z is the outlier here, with their payments still growing at a healthy rate, increasing almost 6% YoY for both 2026 and 2025, after a 7% increase in 2024. Meanwhile, Millennials and Baby Boomers experienced a 2% YoY increase so far this year, with Gen X only seeing around a 1% rise.

Exhibit 2: Insurance payment growth is easing significantly for every generation except Gen Z
Median insurance payments by age generation (September to August yearly, YoY%)

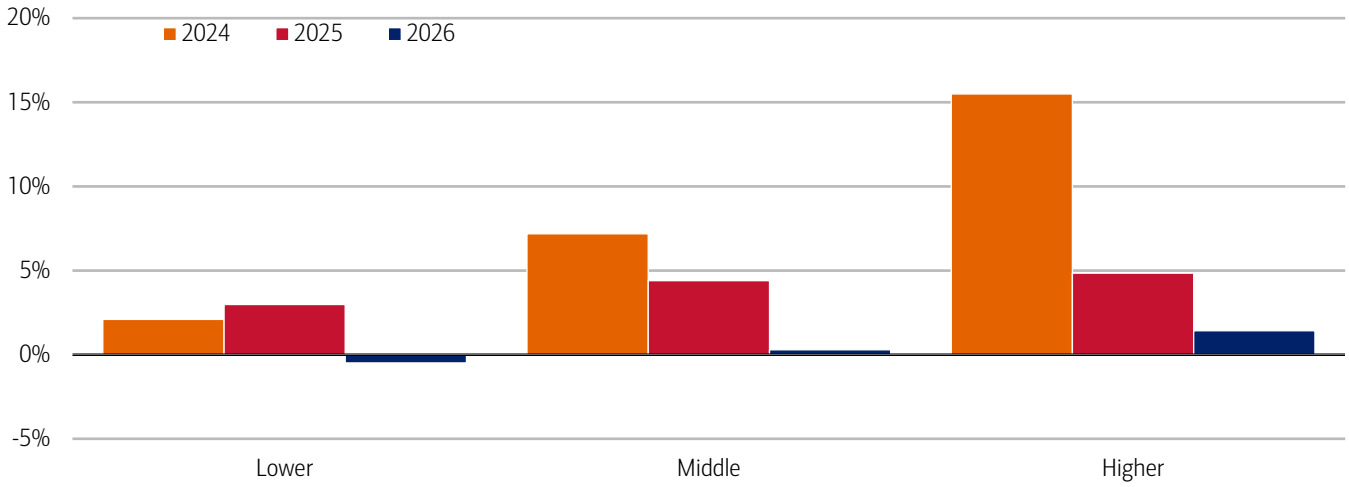


Source: Bank of America internal data

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Bank of America payments data by income provides even more insight. Higher-income households paid nearly 1.5% more in 2026 than they did a year ago, while middle-income households saw only modest increases or none at all (Exhibit 3). Conversely, lower-income households actually paid slightly less so far this year than they did last year.

Exhibit 3: Higher-income households are still paying more for insurance compared to last year, while lower earners are paying less
Median insurance payments by income cuts (September to August yearly, YoY%)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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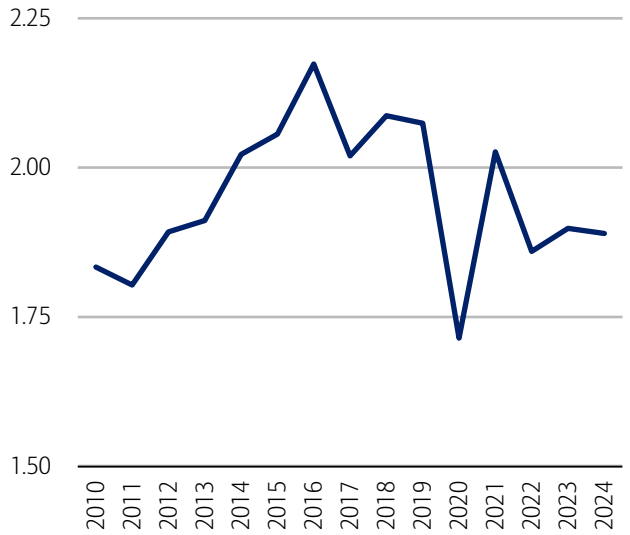
Fewer accidents and lower vehicles prices may be driving insurance payments down

But why might insurance payments be declining at all? One thing to keep in mind is that insurance companies often raise rates to cover events that occurred in previous years to recover costs, while adjusting for changing risks.

For example, the crash rate – the number of vehicle crashes per one million miles driven – suggests that there was a sharp rise in accidents in 2021, according to the Department of Transportation (Exhibit 4). Additionally, new and used vehicle prices increased significantly after the pandemic, according to Consumer Price Index (CPI) data from the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) (Exhibit 5). So, insurers were not only facing more vehicle replacements due to a higher crash rate, but a higher cost to replace vehicles as well.

However, the crash rate mostly declined from 2021 to 2024, and the Department of Transportation reported that the number of accidents likely decreased again in 2025. Also, while the cost to maintain and repair vehicles has consistently grown since 2021, the price to replace vehicles peaked in 2022 and has eased since then – the latter likely a more important factor in insurance costs than the former. Additionally, while the CPI index for motor vehicle insurance has fallen 5% YoY, it's possible that this may partially be due to rebates, according to BofA Global Research. So, the price figured into CPI may not be fully realized by the consumer.

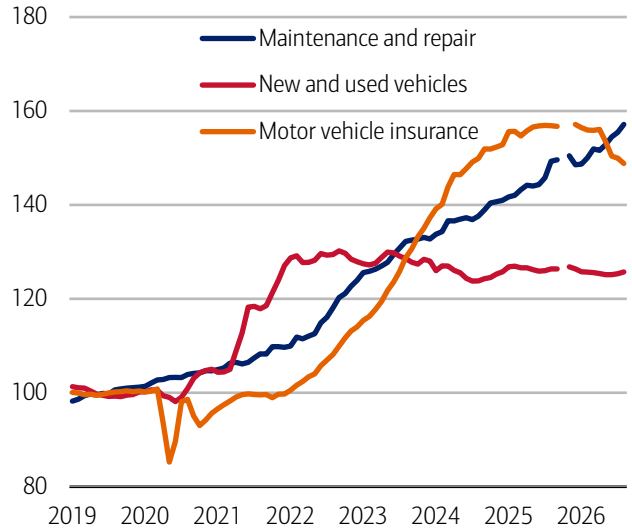
Exhibit 4: The rate of crashes is below pre- and post-pandemic levels
Number of crashes per one million miles driven (yearly, %)



Source: Department of Transportation

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Exhibit 5: New and used vehicle inflation has eased since 2022
CPI for vehicle maintenance and repair, new and used vehicles and motor vehicle insurance (monthly, 2019 average = 100)

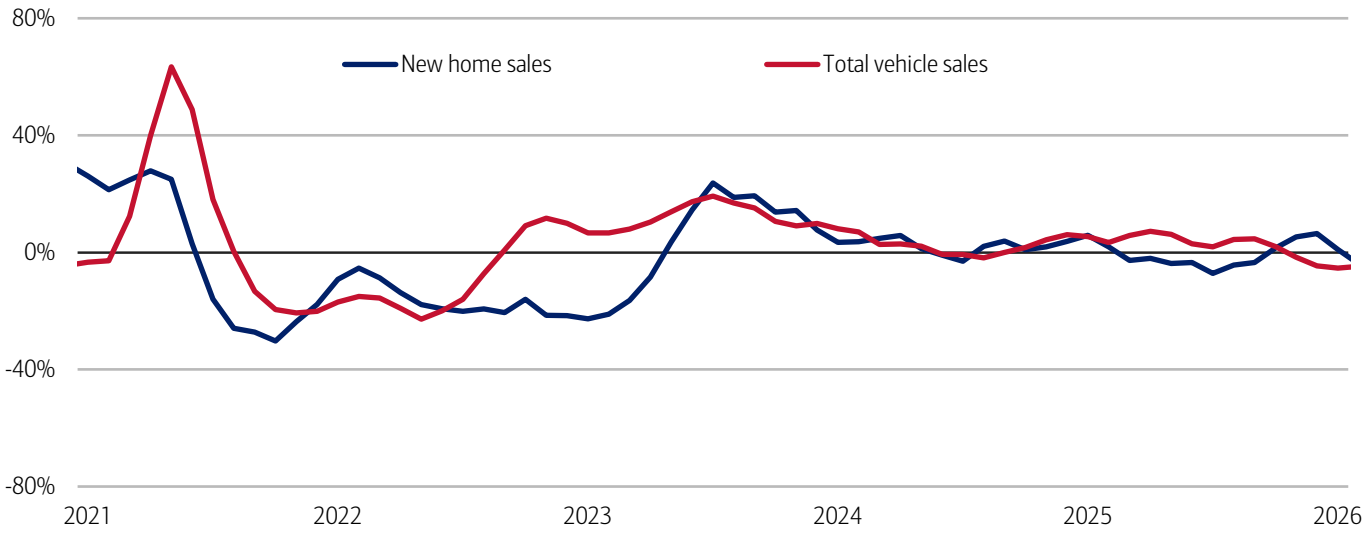


Source: BLS. Some fall 2025 months might be missing due to the government shutdown.

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Another factor in the divergence between a declining CPI and rising insurance payments in our data may be the growth in the amount of property people are insuring now. Notably though, this growth has eased in recent years. YoY growth in both new home and total vehicle sales peaked in mid-2023 and has grown modestly, or even declined, since (Exhibit 6). And given that these major purchases are still K-shaped (read more in Autos: In gear, but the "K" is still in the headlights and On the move: Renovation over relocation?), it could help to explain the divergence in insurance payment growth across income cohorts.

Exhibit 6: Growth in new home and total vehicle sales peaked in mid-2023 due to a post-pandemic boom but has eased since
New home and total vehicles sales (three-month moving average, YoY%)



Source: Haver analytics

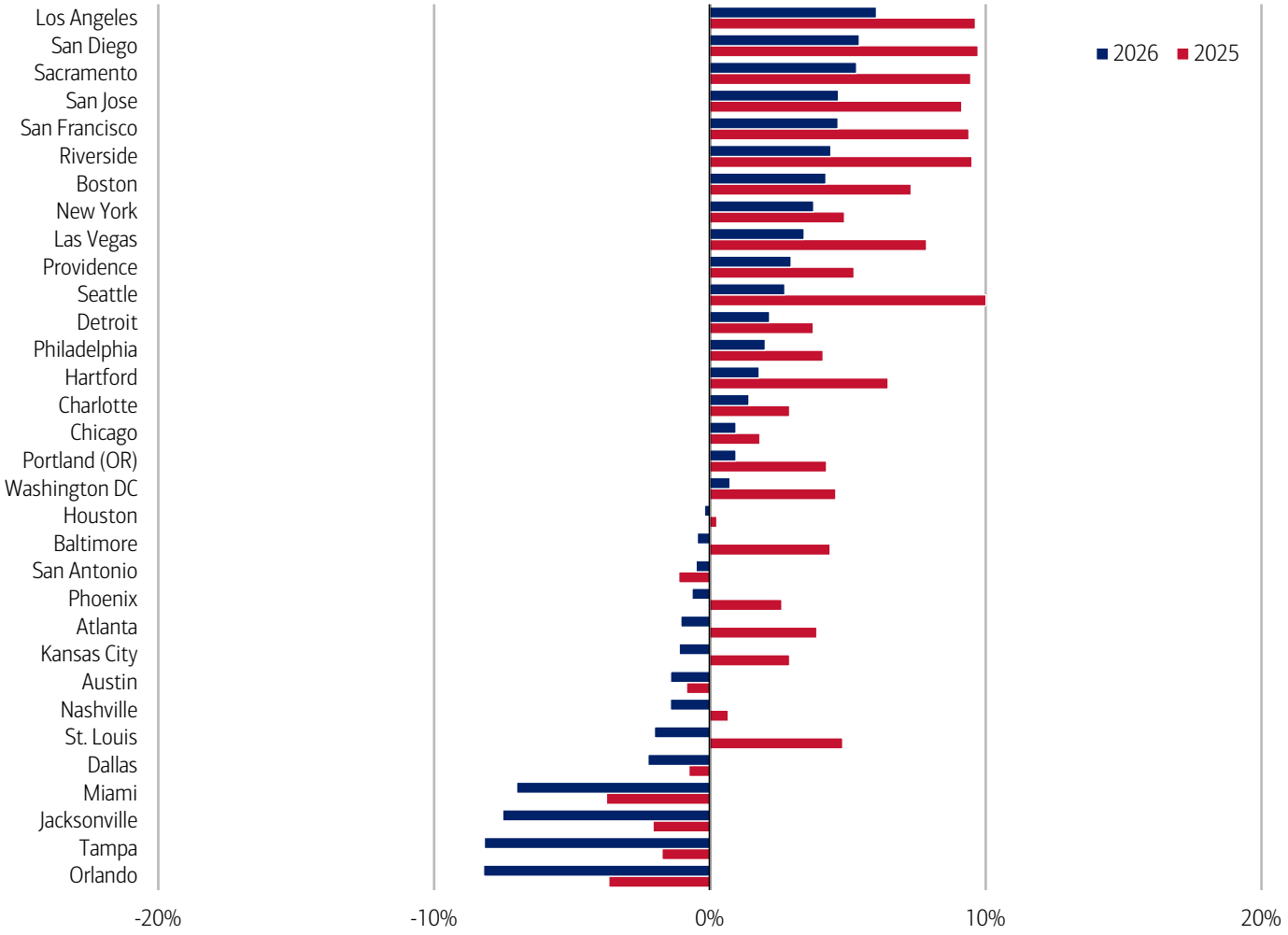
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Florida's metros have seen the largest decline when compared to other major cities

Examining different cities across the US also sheds light on insurance trends. Consumers in major California metros saw the largest increases in 2026, following near double digit growth in 2025, likely driven by widespread property damage from wildfires, according to BofA Global Research (Exhibit 7). Major coastal metros in the Northeast like Boston and New York also experienced sizable increases as well.

Conversely, many cities throughout the Sun Belt like Houston, Nashville and Dallas saw flat or even declining insurance payments. BofA Global Research points to several reasons for these declines: part of the equation in this region is that the massive runup in the cost of property insurance and domestic migration to the region through 2024 has since eased or reversed course.

Exhibit 7: California major metros have seen steady insurance payment growth, while Miami metros have seen declines
Median insurance payments by core based statistical areas (September to August yearly, YoY%)



Source: Bank of America internal data

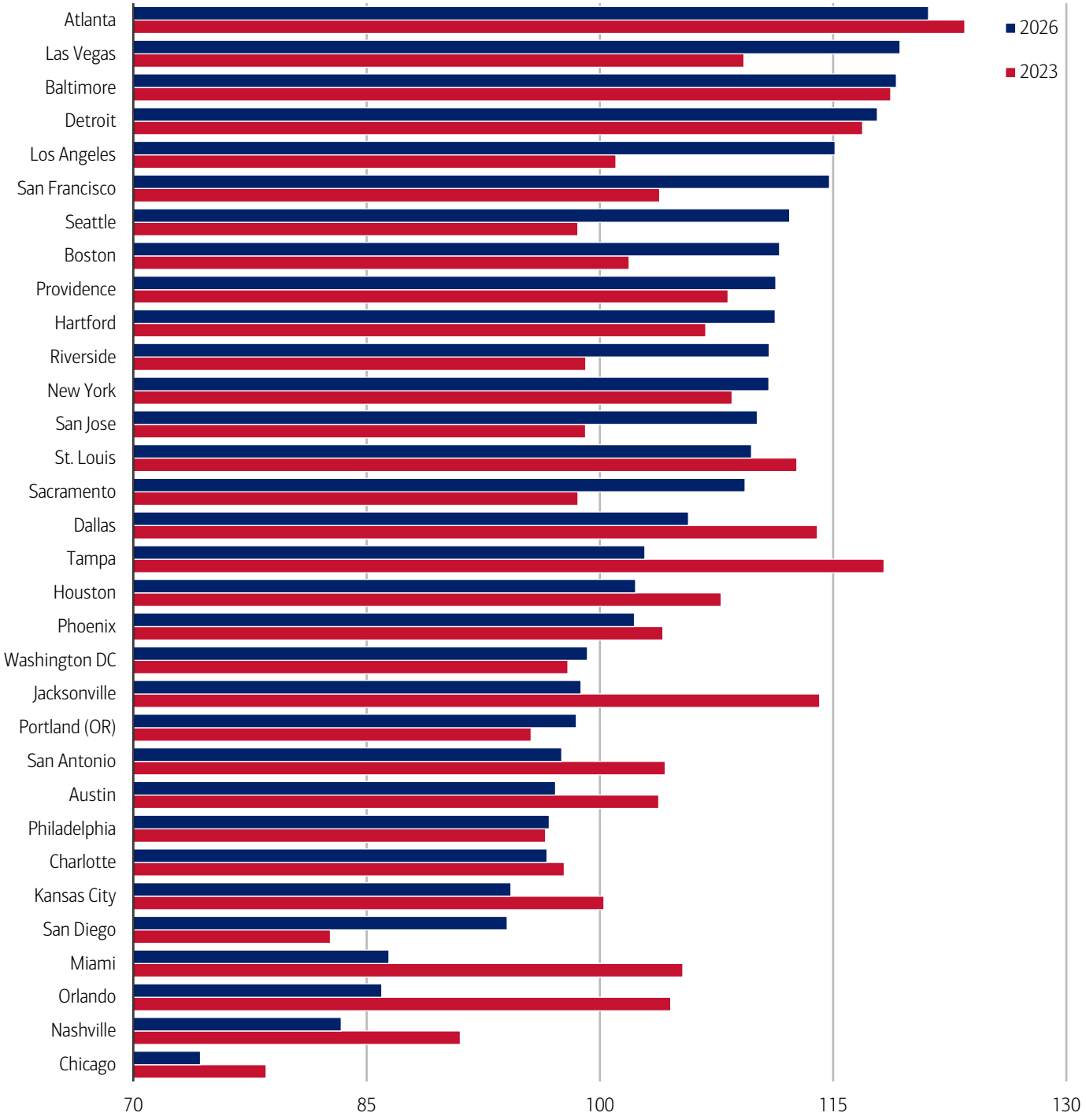
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In Florida, legislation that went into effect in 2023, eventually made its way into insurance prices in 2025, leading to widespread declines in premiums. The state also has a "lookback period" of three years, where insurance profits can be deemed too high and a rebate is issued to consumers. It's possible this rebate is factoring into declines this year, as some carriers only allow rebates upon renewals.

The Sunshine State was a notable standout for declines, with Orlando, Tampa and Jacksonville each down around 8% YoY in 2026, followed closely by Miami with a 7% decrease. Additionally, Bank of America payments data suggests that Jacksonville, Miami and Orlando all had median insurance payments above the national level in 2023, though their payments were fell below that in 2026 (Exhibit 8).

Major metros in Texas also saw easing insurance payments relative to 2023, while Seattle, San Jose, and Riverside, CA are among the major metros that went from below the national median to above in the three-year period ending in 2026.

Exhibit 8: Chicago, Nashville, Orlando and Miami residents have some of the lowest insurance payments in the nation among major metros
Median insurance payments by core based statistical areas (September to August yearly, index to national median = 100)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Any payments data represents aggregated spend from US Retail, Preferred, Small Business and Wealth Management clients with a deposit account or credit card. Aggregated spend include total credit card, debit card, ACH, wires, bill pay, business/peer-to-peer, cash, and checks.

Any **Small Business** payments data represents aggregate spend from Small Business clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card. Payroll payments data include channels such as ACH (automated clearing house), bill pay, checks and wire. Bank of America per Small Business client data represents activity spending from active Small Business clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card and at least one transaction in each month. Small businesses in this report include business clients within Bank of America and generally defined as under $5mm in annual sales revenue.

Unless otherwise stated, data is not adjusted for seasonality, processing days or portfolio changes, and may be subject to periodic revisions.

The differences between the total and per household card spending growth rate (if discussed) can be explained by the following reasons:

1. Overall total card spending growth is partially boosted by the growth in the number of active cardholders in our sample. This could be due to an increasing customer base or inactive customers using their cards more frequently.
2. Per household card spending growth only looks at households that complete at least five transactions with Bank of America cards in the month. Per household spending growth isolates impacts from a changing sample size, which could be unrelated to underlying economic momentum, and potential spending volatility from less active users.
3. Overall total card spending includes small business card spending while per household card spending does not.
4. Differences due to using processing dates (total card spending) versus transaction date (per household card spending).
5. Other differences including household formations due to young adults moving in and out of their parent's houses during COVID.

Any household consumer deposit data based on Bank of America internal data is derived by anonymizing and aggregating data from Bank of America consumer deposit accounts in the US and analyzing that data at a highly aggregated level. Whenever median household savings and checking balances are quoted, the data is based on a fixed cohort of households that had a consumer deposit account (checking and/or savings account) for all months from January 2019 through the most current month of data shown.

Bank of America aggregated credit/debit card spending per household includes spending from active US households only. Only consumer card holders making a minimum of five transactions a month are included in the dataset. Spending from corporate cards are excluded. Data regarding merchants who receive payments are identified and classified by the Merchant Categorization Code (MCC) defined by financial services companies. The data are mapped using proprietary methods from the MCCs to the North American Industry Classification System (NAICS), which is also used by the Census Bureau, in order to classify spending data by subsector. Spending data may also be classified by other proprietary methods not using MCCs.

Insurance payments include renters, auto or home, but do not include insurance escrowed into mortgage payments or deducted from a paycheck.

We consider a measure of services necessity spending that includes but is not limited to groceries, utilities, and gasoline. Discretionary services includes but is not limited to charitable donations, leisure travel, entertainment, and professional/consumer services. Discretionary retail includes but is not limited to general merchandise, miscellaneous, clothing, electronics and furniture. It excludes categories like groceries and gasoline. Holiday spending is defined as items in which spending in the November-December period is usually at least 20% of total annual spending on the category. Value and premium grocers are determined judgmentally on a proprietary analysis of merchants by equity analysts. The "more discretionary" retail category includes furniture, electronics, building materials, online marketplaces, clothing retailers and miscellaneous stores; while "partly discretionary" retail contains auto parts and services, health and personal care retailers, general merchandise and "mostly necessity" retail contains gas and groceries.

Lower, middle and higher household income cuts in Bank of America credit and debit card spending per household, and consumer deposit account data are based on quantitative estimates of each households' income. These quantitative estimates are bucketed according to terciles, with a third of households placed in each tercile periodically. The lowest tercile represents 'lower income', the middle tercile represents 'middle income' and the highest tercile 'higher income'. The income thresholds between these terciles will move over time, reflecting any number of factors that impact income, including general wage inflation, changes in social security payments and individual households' income. The income and tercile in which a household is categorised are periodically re-assessed.

Generations, if discussed, are defined as follows: Gen Z, born after 1995; Younger Millennials: born between 1989-1995; Older Millennials: born between 1978-1988; Gen Xers: born between 1965-1977; Baby Boomer: 1946-1964; Traditionalists: pre-1946.

Any reference to card spending per household on gasoline includes all purchases at gasoline stations and might include purchases of non-gas items.

Additional information about the methodology used to aggregate the data is available upon request.

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Economy

Business Checkpoint: Looking into the logistics

15 October 2026

Key takeaways

- Small and mid-sized businesses entered Q3 in relatively solid financial condition, with profitability growth up across both groups, according to Bank of America business account data. Nearly half of estimated tariff payments had been refunded by September, though the share of these refunds relative to revenue has peaked.
- In Bank of America business payments data, logistics spending growth per client was up four times as much for small than mid-sized firms. Additionally, distribution and inventory transactions growth per client has outpaced spending since the spring of 2025.
- Growing transportation bottlenecks are re-emerging ahead of the holiday season. Trucking capacity has tightened as driver availability remains constrained, according to BofA Global Research. This has pushed freight rates higher and driven strong transportation sector payroll growth, particularly among mid-sized businesses, according to Bank of America payments data.

Business Checkpoint is a new, regular publication from Bank of America Institute. It provides a real-time view of the financial health, opportunities and challenges facing small and mid-sized businesses across the US economy, leveraging the depth and breadth of Bank of America's proprietary data. By analyzing activity among both small and mid-sized firms, Business Checkpoint offers timely insights into business profitability, hiring, investment and spending trends. Such data is not intended to be reflective or indicative of, and should not be relied upon as, the results of operations, financial condition or performance of Bank of America.

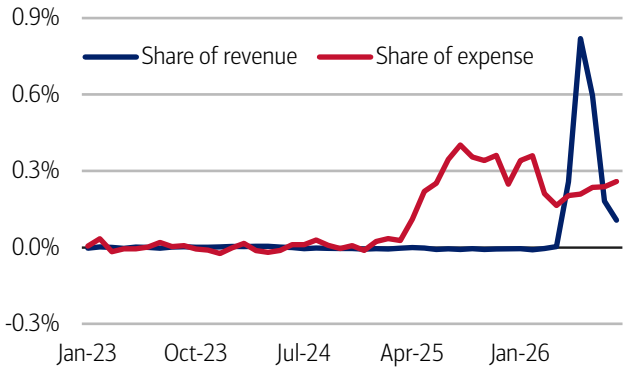
Businesses end Q3 in fair shape

While profitability growth remained positive for both small and mid-sized firms in the third quarter, small firms outpaced their mid-sized counterparts for the second consecutive quarter (Exhibit 2). Still, there's been a notable reversal in the profitability of mid-sized businesses, growing this quarter after declining slightly for the past two.

The continued rollout of tariff refunds is serving as a tailwind to some firms' cash positions. That is particularly true for small firms. According to Bank of America account data, by September approximately 47% of estimated International Emergency Economic Powers Act-related tariff payments had been refunded to companies with less than $50 million in annual revenue.

Exhibit 1: Tariff refunds as a share of income for businesses <$50M in annual revenue peaked in June

Share of tariff payments of income and expense (percentage point difference from 2023 average share)

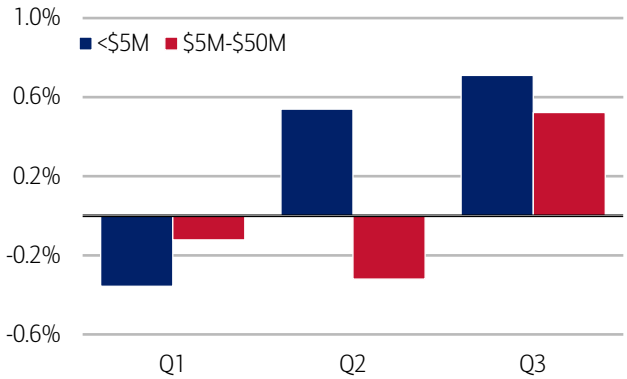


Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 2: Small firms' profitability growth outpaced mid-sized firms in Q3 2026

Profitability growth by firm size in 2026 (quarterly average, year-over-year (YoY)%)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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According to Bank of America business payments data, the percentage point difference in tariff refunds as a share of revenue for firms with less than $50 million in annual revenue spiked in June but dropped to nearly zero in September. At the same time, the percentage point difference in tariff payments as a share of expenses began rising again relative to the 2023 average (Exhibit 1). This suggests that while tariffs continue to affect companies, the refund program has provided temporary relief for some businesses.

Wholesale trade along with transportation and warehousing posted solid profitability growth across business size

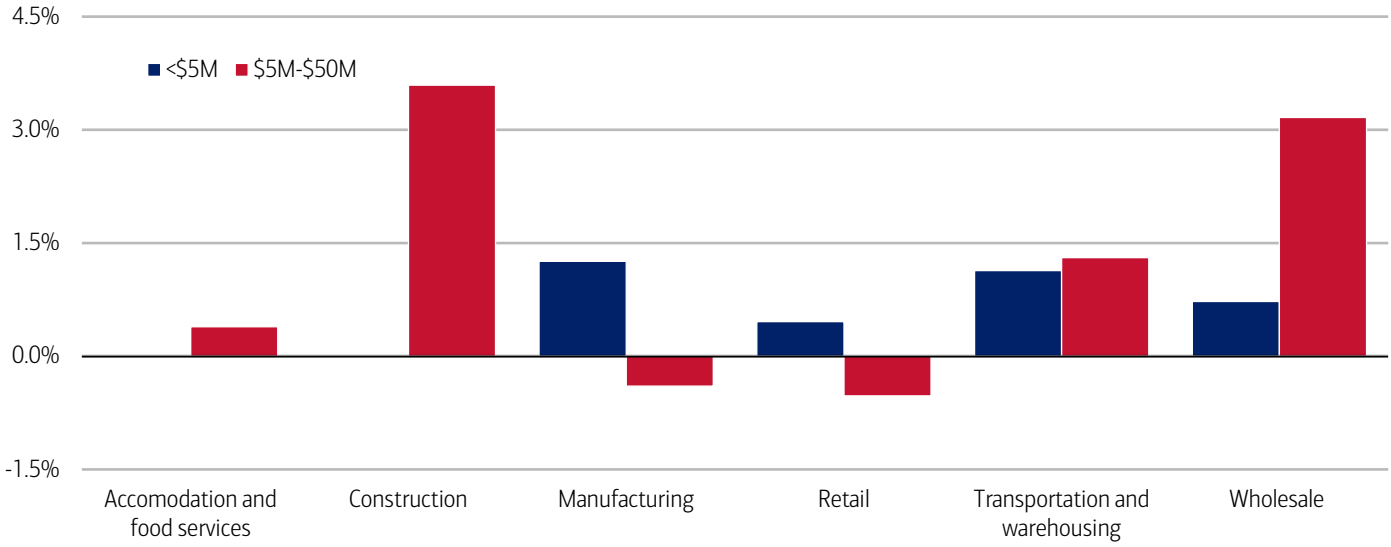
However, the benefits appear uneven. Such refunds have boosted cash flow, but they have not fully insulated firms from broader cost pressures.

Looking across industries, mid-sized construction and wholesale firms had the strongest profitability growth in September (Exhibit 3). Notably, transportation and warehousing, as well as wholesale trade were among the few sectors showing positive profitability growth for both small and mid-sized firms last month.

The persistence of logistics, freight and inventory-related cost pressures may help explain why profitability gains have remained relatively concentrated in transportation and wholesale trade. However, these sectors also have a higher exposure to rising gas prices within their margins (read more on this in the August Small Business Checkpoint).

Exhibit 3: For both small and mid-sized businesses, profitability growth was positive in transportation and warehousing as well as wholesale trade in September

Profitability growth by sector and business size in September (YoY%, six-month moving average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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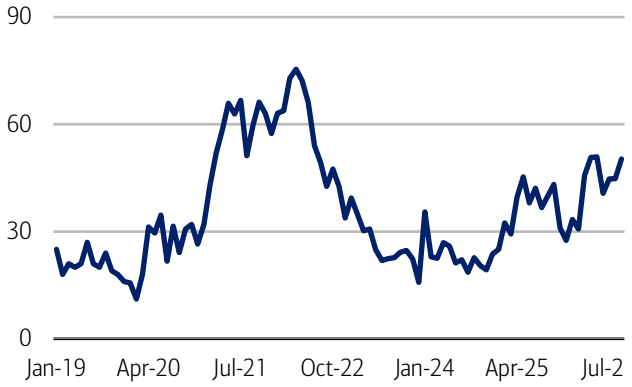
The cost of maintaining supply chains is rising

In fact, the prices paid component of the September services reading from the Institute for Supply Management indicates still-building price pressure for firms (Exhibit 4). This marked the highest reading since July 2022.

Using Bank of America internal data, we identified payments to logistics and freight companies to assess a key part of supply chain costs. In June, logistics and freight payments' growth per client from small businesses grew nearly 30%, though has moderated to 12.7% YoY in September (Exhibit 5). Meanwhile, mid-sized firms' payments growth in this category was up just 3.2% YoY in September.

The divergence suggests logistics costs may be disproportionately affecting smaller firms, who are typically less capable of absorbing rising costs than larger firms. Larger companies also often benefit from dedicated logistics contracts and greater purchasing power, while smaller ones may be more exposed to spot-market transportation costs and fluctuations in freight pricing.

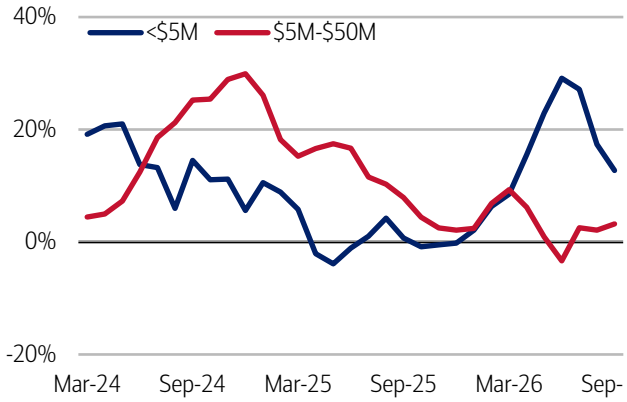
Exhibit 4: The September services Institute for Supply Management higher prices component was the highest reading since July 2022
Institute for Supply Management: Services: Prices, Higher (% of respondents)



Source: Haver Analytics

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Exhibit 5: Logistics and freight payments' growth by small businesses peaked in June
Logistics and freight payments by business size (YoY%, monthly, three-month moving average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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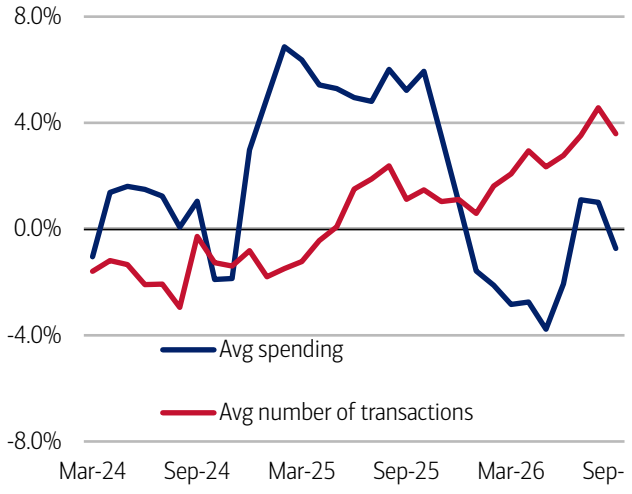
Evidence of more moving parts in companies' supply chains

Yet there is increasing evidence that tariffs and geopolitics are adding complexity to small and mid-sized companies' supply chains.

In Bank of America payments data, average distribution and inventory transaction growth per business client has increased steadily since the spring of 2025 despite spending growth in this category falling in September (Exhibit 6). Rising transaction growth alongside softer spending growth suggests businesses may be engaging with more suppliers, shipments or inventory movements even as overall procurement outlays moderates.

Furthermore, in May 2026, the Global Supply Chain Pressure Index reached its highest reading since the summer of 2022 and has continued to remain elevated into October (Exhibit 7). This further emphasizes that transportation bottlenecks, delays and procurement challenges are becoming more common globally. While current readings remain below the extreme levels observed during the pandemic, the recent move higher indicates supply chain normalization may be reversing.

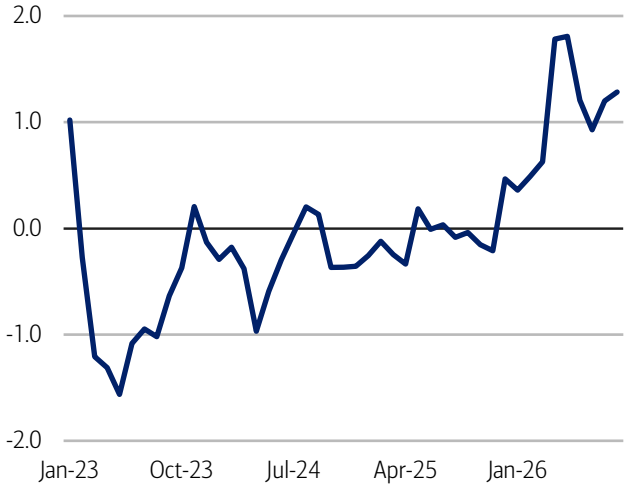
Exhibit 6: Average distribution and inventory transaction growth per business client has increased steadily since the spring of 2025
Payments and transactions to distribution and inventory per client (monthly, YoY%, three-month moving average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 7: The Global Supply Chain Pressure Index reached its highest reading since the summer of 2022 in May 2026
Global Supply Chain Pressure Index (monthly)



Source: Federal Reserve Bank of New York, Global Supply Chain Pressure Index, https://www.newyorkfed.org/research/gscpi.html.

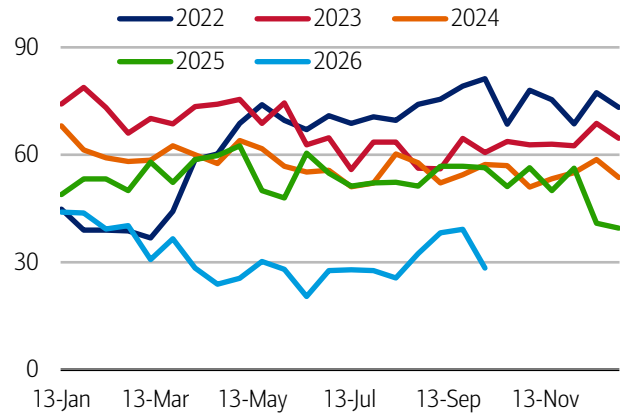
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The trials of trucking

As of October 1, BofA Global Research's proprietary bi-weekly Truckload Demand Indicator (see Methodology) remained below its historical growth signal (Exhibit 9) and the Truck Capacity Indicator, which reflects shippers' views of available capacity, tightened significantly, falling from 39.2 to 28.4 (Exhibit 8). This suggests shippers are seeing fewer trucks available relative to demand than in the previous survey.

According to BofA Global Research, the current trucking upcycle is being driven by constrained supply rather than a significant improvement in freight demand. While any positive movement in demand is an important indicator as the industry moves into peak shipping season between late September and early December, tighter capacity appears to be the dominant force supporting freight rates.

Exhibit 8: Shippers' view of available capacity has fallen significantly as of October 1, 2026
BofA Truckload Capacity Indicator by year (bi-weekly)



Source: BofA Global Research

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Exhibit 9: The Demand Indicator has been sub-60 for the past two months after 4.5 months above
BofA Truckload Demand Indicator (bi-weekly)



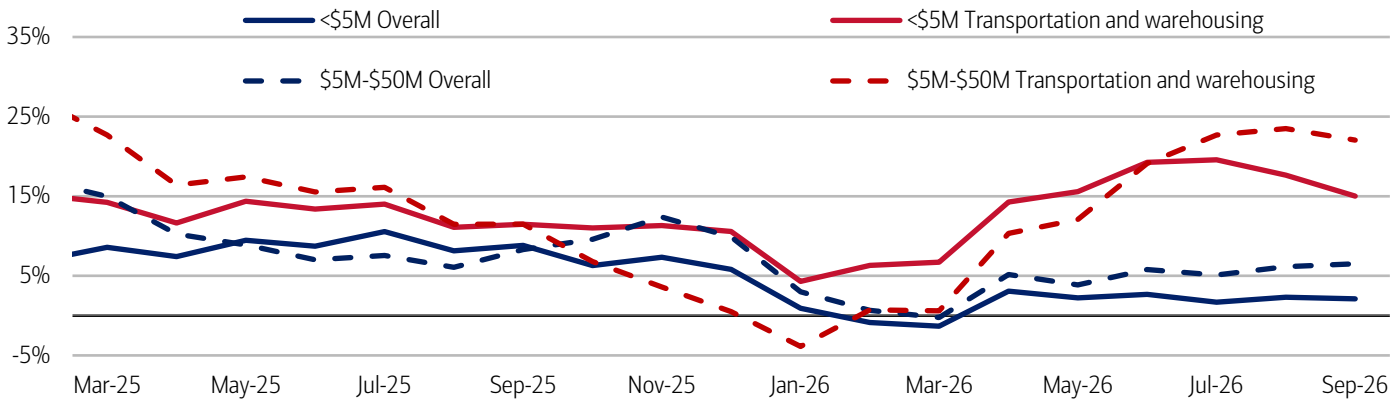
Source: BofA Global Research

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The reduction in capacity reflects several factors, including stricter commercial driver's license (CDL) and training requirements, increased compliance and enforcement measures, and other regulatory changes that have reduced the pool of qualified drivers. This has also likely driven some wage inflation within the industry. According to Bank of America payments data, transportation and warehousing payroll growth per client has surged since the start of the year, especially for mid-sized businesses (Exhibit 10).

Having to pay higher wages suggests labor shortages remain a challenge in the sector. Firms may increasingly need to offer higher compensation to attract and retain workers as trucking capacity tightens. In turn, such capacity puts upward pressure on freight rates, particularly in the spot market where small businesses may be more impacted.

Exhibit 10: Transportation and warehousing payroll growth has surged since the start of the year, especially for mid-sized businesses
Payroll payments per client by industry and business size (monthly, YoY%, three-month moving average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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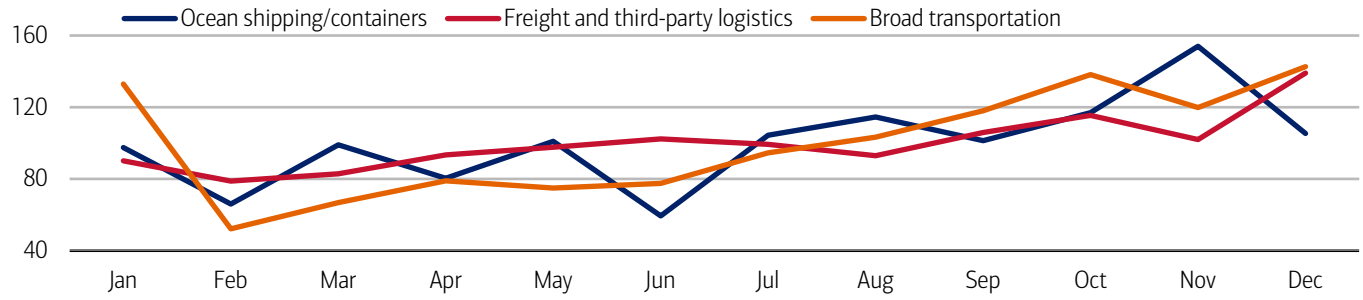
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Logistics payments tend to increase in the second half of the year

September marks a key run-up to the holiday season (read more on signs of holiday spending in the October Consumer Checkpoint), with spending on ocean shipping, containers, and other transportation services steadily accelerating ahead of the peak shopping period.

In fact, over the past two years, the month of November has seen ocean shipping/container spending volumes well above their 2023-2025 monthly average (Exhibit 11). The seasonal pattern likely reflects inventory restocking and holiday-related shipping activity. Ocean shipping volumes typically accelerate during the fall months as businesses prepare for year-end demand.

Exhibit 11: Ocean shipping/container spending volumes were well above their 2023-2025 monthly average in November
Logistics and freight average payments by category (monthly, indexed, 100 = monthly 2023-2025 average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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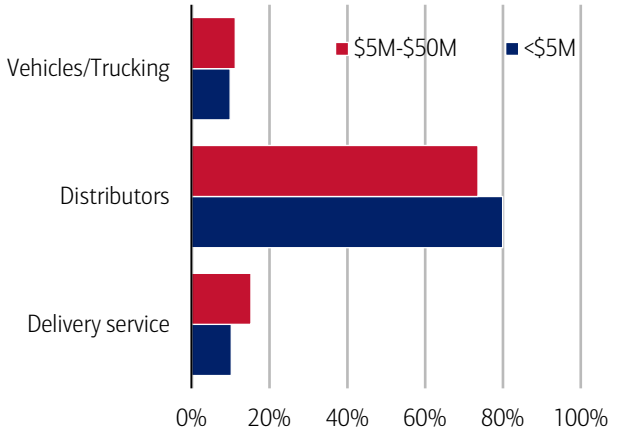
Distributors and inventory payments' growth fell ahead of holiday season

Changes in logistics and freight spending often provide an early signal of inventory trends, as distributors account for a large share of supply chain-related spending (Exhibit 12).

The sharp moderation in distribution and inventory spending growth per client for both small and mid-sized businesses indicates that much of the large-scale inventory accumulation seen earlier in 2025 has already occurred (Exhibit 13). In other words, businesses appear to be replenishing inventories for seasonal demand rather than significantly expanding stockpiles as they did earlier in the year.

Overall, businesses seem to be entering the holiday season in relatively stable financial condition, supported by tariff refunds and positive profitability growth. However, rising logistics costs, tighter trucking capacity and elevated supply chain pressures suggest operating conditions are becoming more challenging.

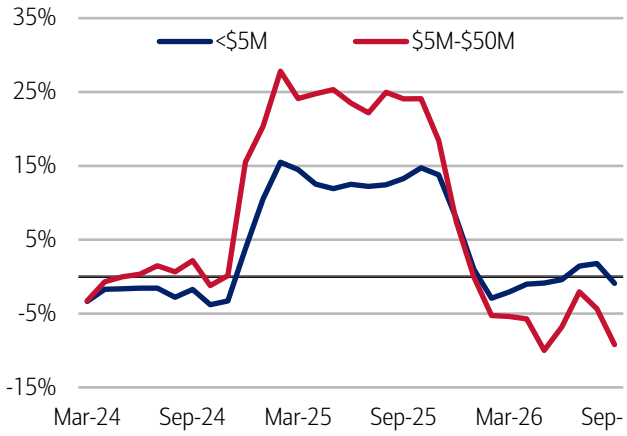
Exhibit 12: Distributors comprise a sizeable share of overall supply chain-related payments
Share of supply chain-related payments by category in 2026 by business size (%)



Source: Bank of America internal data
Note: Supply chain-related payments are those towards companies within logistics, freight, distribution and inventory.

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Exhibit 13: For both small and mid-sized firms, payments growth to distribution and inventory firms accelerated sharply during 2025
Payments to distribution and inventory by business size (monthly, YoY%, three-month moving average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Methodology

Selected Bank of America transaction data is used to inform the macroeconomic views expressed in this report and should be considered in the context of other economic indicators and publicly available information. In certain instances, the data may provide directional and/or predictive value. The data used is not comprehensive; it is based on **aggregated and anonymized** selections of Bank of America data and may reflect a degree of selection bias and limitations on the data available.

Any **Business** payments data represents aggregate spend from Small Business and/or Business Banking clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card. Payroll payments data include channels such as ACH (automated clearing house), bill pay, checks and wire. Bank of America per Business client data represents activity spending from active Business clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card and at least one transaction in each month. Small businesses in this report include business clients within Bank of America and are generally defined as under $5mm in annual sales revenue. Mid-sized businesses in this report include business clients within Bank of America and are generally defined as $5mm-$50mm in annual sales revenue.

Unless otherwise stated, data is not adjusted for seasonality, processing days or portfolio changes, and may be subject to periodic revisions.

Revenue tiers are determined by the combination of following factors: 1) stated revenue on small businesses credit applications, 2) actual account inflow into Bank of America Deposit Accounts, and 3) third party revenue estimation.

The alternative hiring indicator consists of payments from Bank of America business clients to business-focused hiring firms which include both direct deposits through Automated Clearing House (ACH) and payments via credit and debit cards.

Supply chain-related spending is comprised of payments to logistics, freight, distribution, inventory, delivery service, and trucking companies. These are identified from merchant names and MCC codes.

BofA Global Research's trucking indicators are a bi-weekly diffusion-style survey of shipper demand expectations over the next 0–3 months, built from responses from surveyed shippers.

Data regarding merchants who receive payments are identified and classified by the Merchant Categorization Code (MCC) defined by financial services companies. The data are mapped using proprietary methods from the MCCs to the North American Industry Classification System (NAICS), which is also used by the Census Bureau, in order to classify spending data by subsector. Spending data may also be classified by other proprietary methods not using MCCs.

Additional information about the methodology used to aggregate the data is available upon request.

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Economy

Consumer Checkpoint: Strength in numbers

09 October 2026

Key takeaways

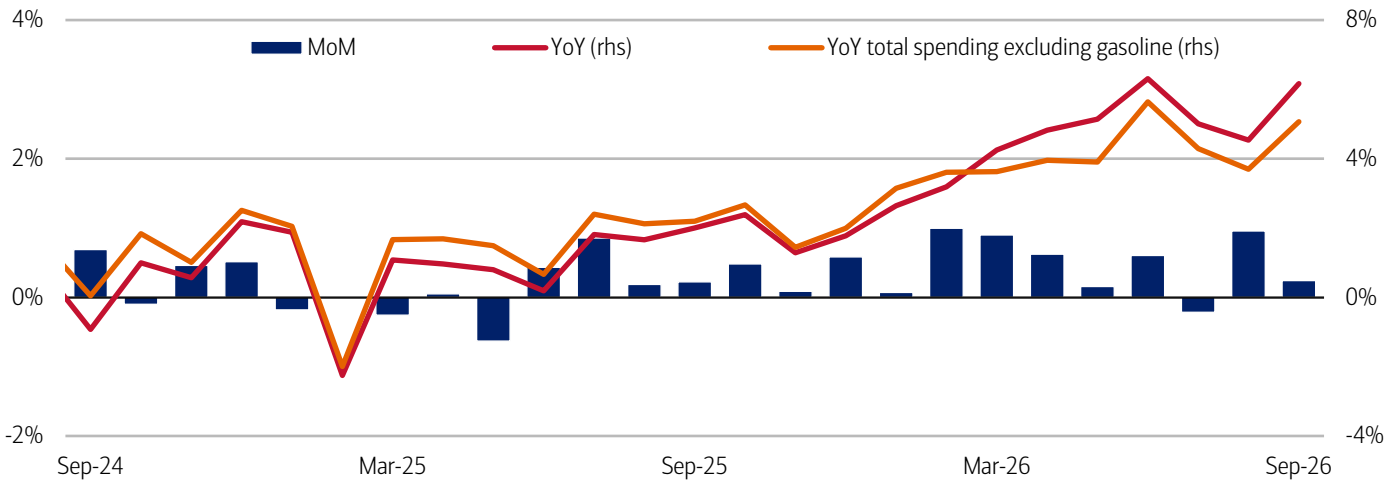
- Consumer spending remained very solid in September. Bank of America aggregated credit and debit card spending per household rose 6.2% year-over-year (YoY), or 5.1% excluding gasoline, both the third strongest growth rates over the past four years. Month-over-month (MoM) spending was more muted, especially without gas.
- Spending shows considerable breadth: the vast majority of discretionary retail and services categories are showing growth. Moreover, this strength extends across income cohorts, with the ongoing recovery of lower- and middle-income households' spending growth.
- With the winter months fast approaching, holiday spending is already increasing at a solid rate, though it's still early. In Bank of America deposit data through September, buy now, pay later (BNPL) usage is rising but not at a rate that is overly concerning. However, nearly one in every five households that use BNPL has a repayment of over $500.

Consumer Checkpoint is a regular publication from Bank of America Institute. It aims to provide a holistic and real-time estimate of US consumers' spending and their financial well-being, leveraging the depth and breadth of Bank of America proprietary data. Such data is not intended to be reflective or indicative of, and should not be relied upon as, the results of operations, financial conditions or performance of Bank of America.

A solid September for spending

Consumer spending continued to look solid in September. Bank of America total aggregated credit and debit card spending per household rose 6.2% year-over-year (YoY), while spending excluding gasoline increased 5.1% YoY. Notably, both are the third strongest growth rates in the past four years. Seasonally-adjusted total card spending rose 0.2% month-over-month (MoM), while spending excluding gasoline was little changed. Overall, spending growth remains well above the 2025 average rate (Exhibit 1).

Exhibit 1: Total card spending per household rose 6.2% YoY and 5.1% YoY excluding gasoline in September
Total card spending growth per household, based on Bank of America aggregated credit and debit card data (monthly, MoM%, seasonally adjusted (SA)) and (monthly, YoY%, non-SA, right-hand side (rhs))



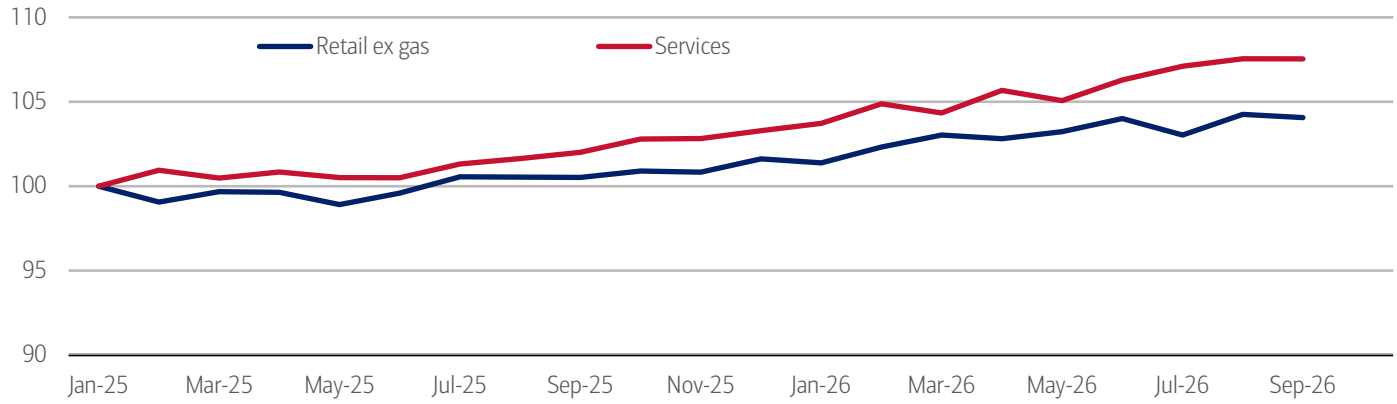
Source: Bank of America internal data

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Most spending categories are growing

One striking thing about recent card spending, in our view, is that it is well balanced across categories. For example, both spending on retail (excluding gasoline) and services grew strongly YoY in September, at 3.5% and 5.4%, respectively. Meanwhile, retail spending is showing notably better momentum than in 2025 (Exhibit 2).

Exhibit 2: Spending is rising across retail and services
Retail (excluding gasoline) and services card spending per household (monthly, seasonally adjusted, index January 2025 = 100)



Source: Bank of America internal data

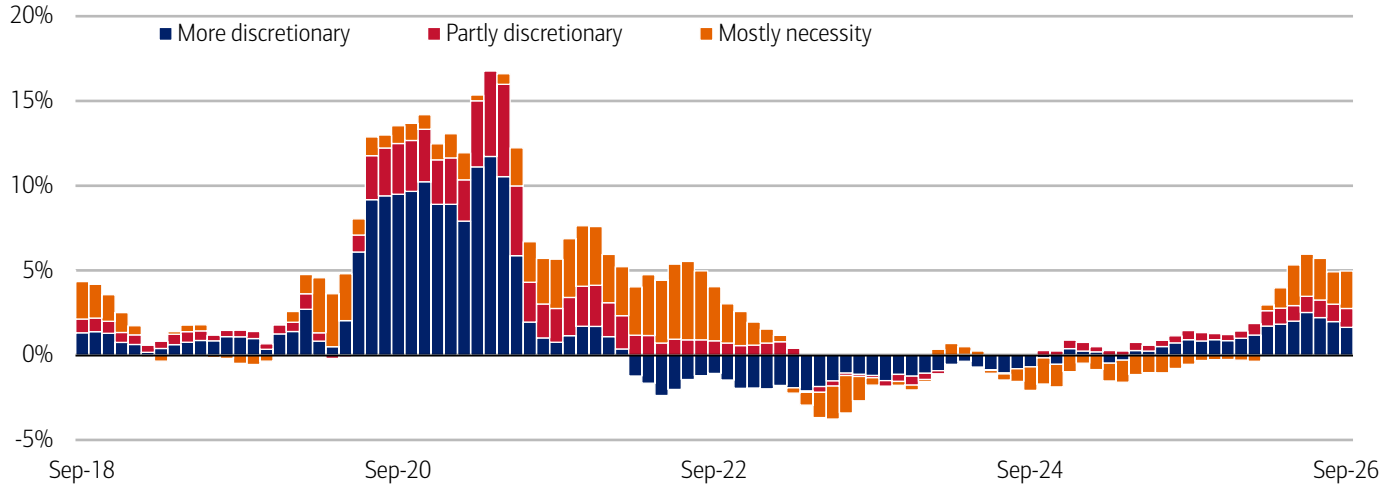
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Well balanced across "nice-to-have" and "need-to-have" retail categories

Is the momentum in retail spending reflective of "nice-to-have" discretionary or "need-to-have" necessity spending? In retail, this is a nuanced question, as many categories sit in a gray area between "necessity" and "discretionary". General merchandise stores, for example, sell both essentials like groceries as well as nice-to-have electronics or even jewelry.

In Exhibit 3, we account for this by grouping retail spending into "more discretionary" (furniture, electronics, building materials, online retailers, clothing retailers and miscellaneous stores), "partly discretionary" (auto, health and personal care retailers, general merchandise) and "mostly necessity" (gas and groceries). Even within these categories the edges will be blurred, but the overall impression is that retail spending growth is widely distributed, with spending rising across all fronts. One caveat: "mostly discretionary" spending has been making a smaller contribution since June.

Exhibit 3: Retail spending is distributed across discretionary and necessity categories
Percentage points contribution to YoY growth by type of retail spending (three-month moving average)



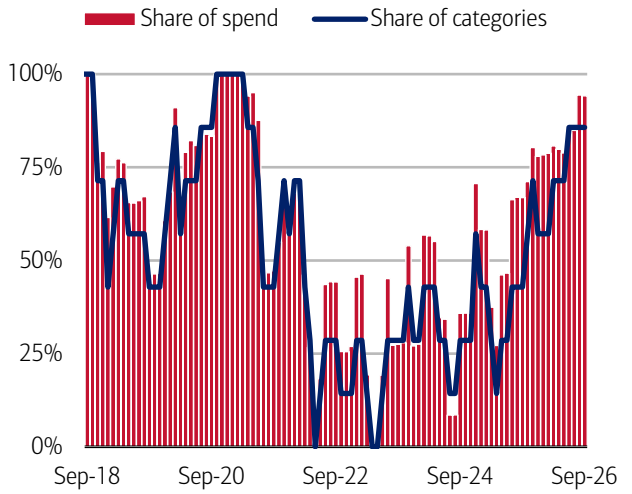
Source: Bank of America internal data. See methodology for category aggregation definitions.

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Looking at the share of "more discretionary" retail spending categories that are increasing YoY underscores that growth is well balanced and broad-based (Exhibit 4). Non-store and online retailers and miscellaneous stores saw some of the fastest growth, while furniture and building materials were among the laggards, though other durable categories showed some strength.

While some of this spending growth likely reflects the impact of higher prices pushing up spending across a swathe of categories, looking just at transactions as a proxy for volumes shows a similar picture, with only slightly less diffusion (Exhibit 5).

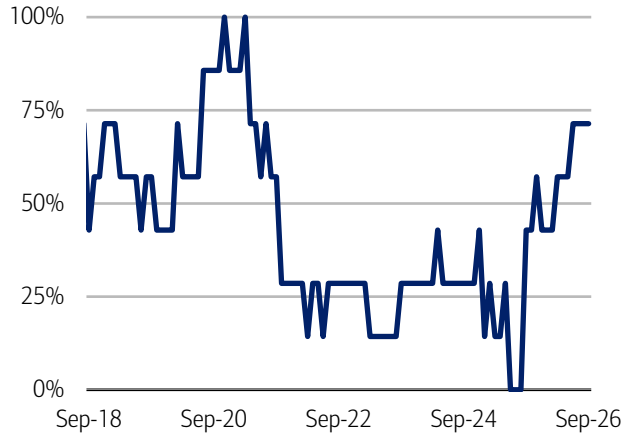
Exhibit 4: Nearly 86% of categories are experiencing positive spending growth, accounting for over 94% of retail spending
Diffusion index across "more discretionary" retail categories by spending (monthly, %)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 5: 71% of retail categories have positive transaction growth, with durables responsible for the declines
Diffusion index across "more discretionary" retail categories by transactions (monthly, %)



Source: Bank of America internal data

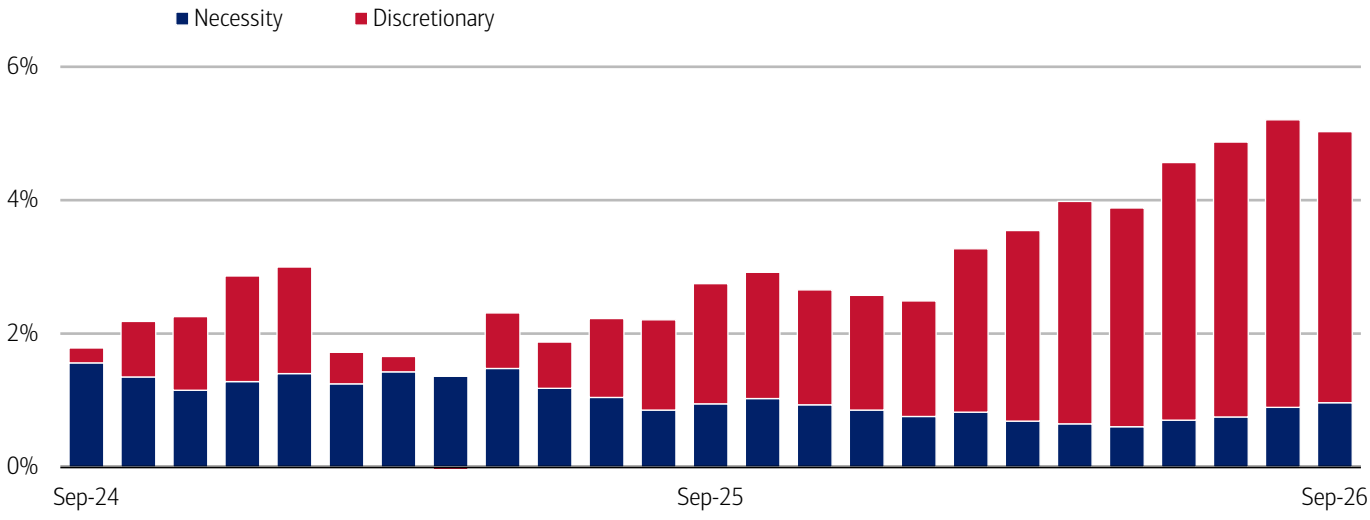
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For services, growth is driven mostly by discretionary spending

In services spending, on the other hand, the boundaries between discretionary and necessity spending are often clearer. Travel spending (e.g., airlines, lodging) can be thought of as, by and large, discretionary. At the same time, utility bills, rent and insurance payments are necessities.

And in services, discretionary spending remains the clear driver, accounting for over three-quarters of YoY spending growth in September (Exhibit 6). Leisure and housing services are major components of growth, though travel and restaurants also made positive contributions. However, as we noted last month strength in airline spending largely reflects price rises rather than transactions growth (read more in Consumer Checkpoint: Still sizzling).

Exhibit 6: Services spending growth has been mostly driven by discretionary spending over the past year
Percentage points contribution to growth by type of services spending (three-month moving average)



Source: Bank of America internal data

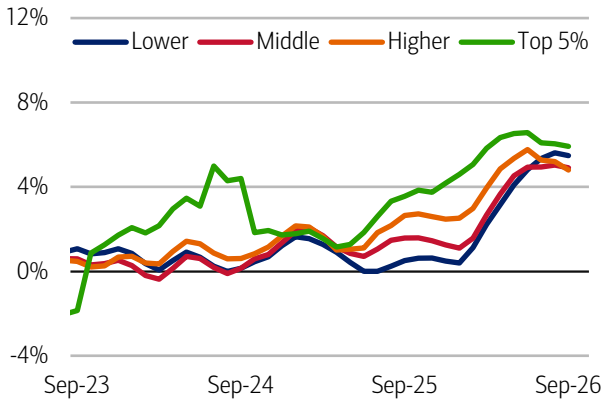
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Lower-income households' spending outpaced all but the top 5%

The breadth in spending growth across categories is also evident across income cohorts. In September, lower-income households' total card spending growth was 5.5% YoY, while the equivalent figures for middle- and higher-income households were 4.9% and 4.8% YoY, respectively. The top 5% of households by income continue to show the fastest spending growth, 5.9% in September, though this has eased somewhat (Exhibit 7).

Overall, the divergences across income cohorts are much smaller than they were in 2025 and the first three months of this year. Just focusing on spending excluding key necessities (gasoline, food and utilities) doesn't meaningfully change the picture of convergence across income cohorts (Exhibit 8).

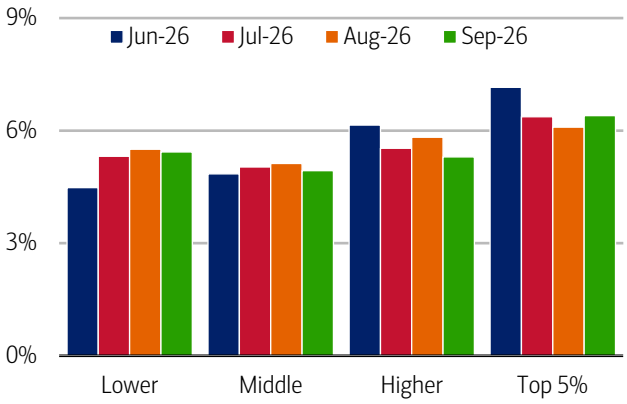
Exhibit 7: The top 5% saw the strongest spending growth of any income cohort…
Total card spending per household by income tercile and the top 5% (three-month moving average, YoY%, SA)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 8: …though discretionary spending for the top 5% has eased some since June
Discretionary card spending per household by income tercile and the top 5% (three-month moving average, YoY%, SA)



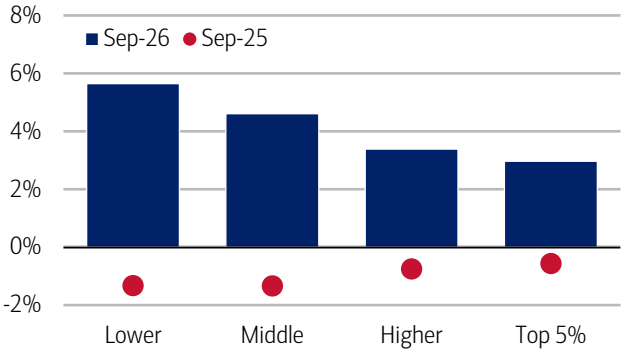
Source: Bank of America internal data

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The strength in lower- and middle-income households' discretionary spending is occurring despite necessity spending shifting from a tailwind to a headwind over the past year amid rising gas prices (Exhibit 9). In our view, a key component of why these households have been able to combine rising necessity spending with strength in discretionary is the labor market and a recovery in their after-tax wage growth (Exhibit 10).

In September, lower-income wage growth eased to 4.5% YoY from 4.7% YoY in August, while growth for middle- and higher-income households rose to 3.8% and 3.7% YoY, respectively. These changes were modest, and lower-income households are continuing to see faster after-tax wage growth than other cohorts, a notable turnaround from the "K-shaped" pattern we observed over much of 2025 and 2026.

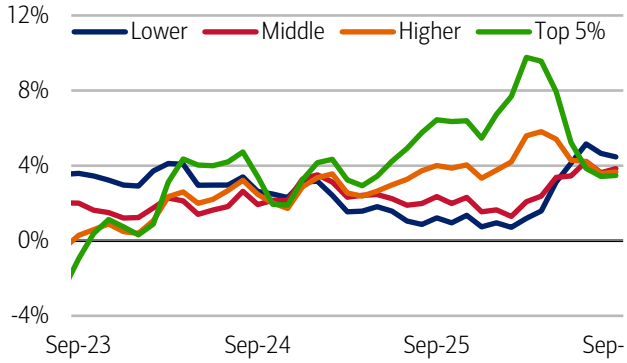
Exhibit 9: Necessity spending has gone from a tailwind to a headwind across all income cohorts
Necessity card spending per household by income tercile and the top 5% (three-month moving average, YoY%, SA)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 10: Lower-income wage growth remains strongest, despite a narrowing gap
After-tax wage and salary growth by household income tercile (three-month moving average, YoY%, SA)

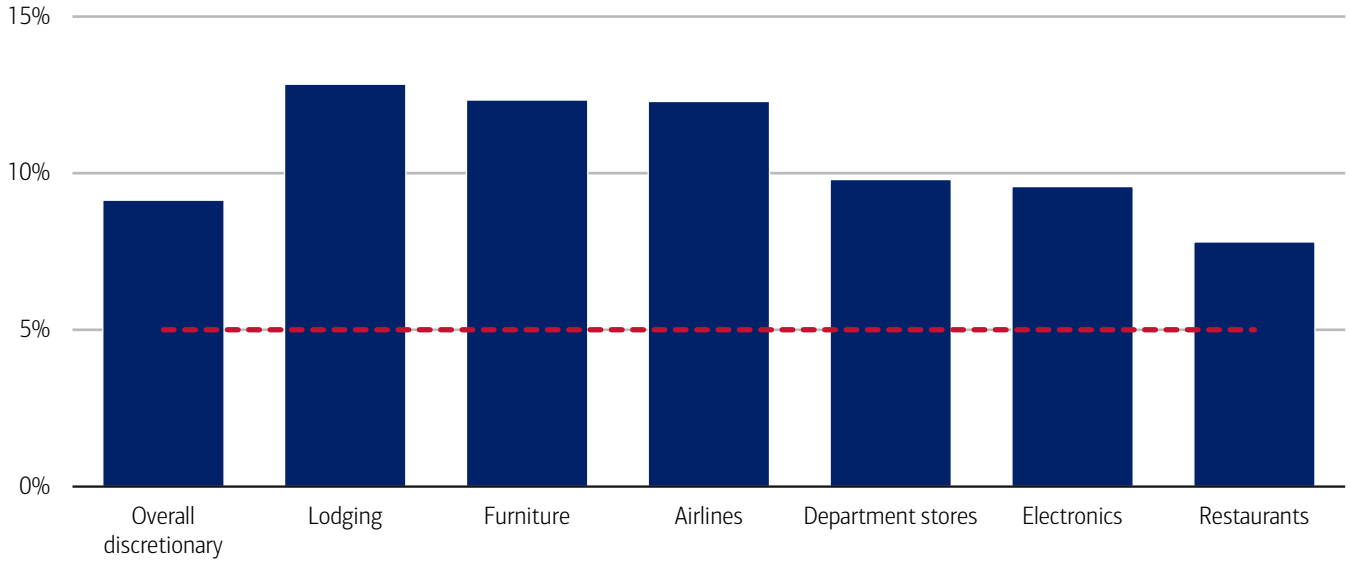


Source: Bank of America internal data

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Should we be concerned about the easing in household spending and after-tax wage growth for those with the top 5% of incomes? For now, probably not, as in our view this spending growth is likely being driven by wealth effects rather than wage gains. Absent a sharp correction in equity markets, there is little reason to expect them to retrench their spending. However, developments here are worth watching as this cohort comprises a significant proportion of overall consumer spending. They also tend to make outsized contributions to several discretionary spending categories (Exhibit 11).

Exhibit 11: The top 5% of households by income make up a disproportionate amount of spending in highly discretionary categories
Share of spending by the top 5% of households by income across select discretionary categories (three-month moving average to September 2026, %)



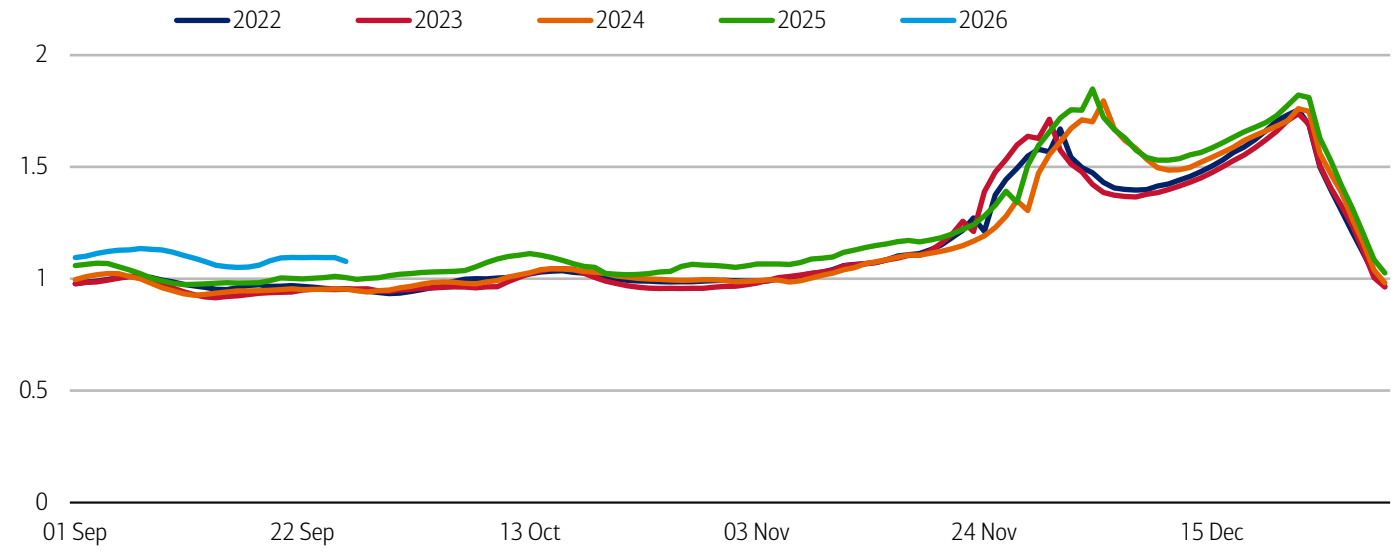
Source: Bank of America internal data

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With summer gone, thoughts turn to the holidays and BNPL...

Now that summer is over, the next big gauge of consumer momentum is how people spend during the run-up to, and over, the holiday season. It is early days, but September spending on holiday items ran well ahead of 2025 (Exhibit 12). Given the backdrop of firmer after-tax wage growth and breadth across retail and services categories, this is perhaps not surprising. However, some of this spending strength could be due to rising prices as opposed to more purchases.

Exhibit 12: It's early days, but holiday spending is strong so far this year
Card spending per household for holiday items by year (seven-day moving average, index September 2025 average = 1)



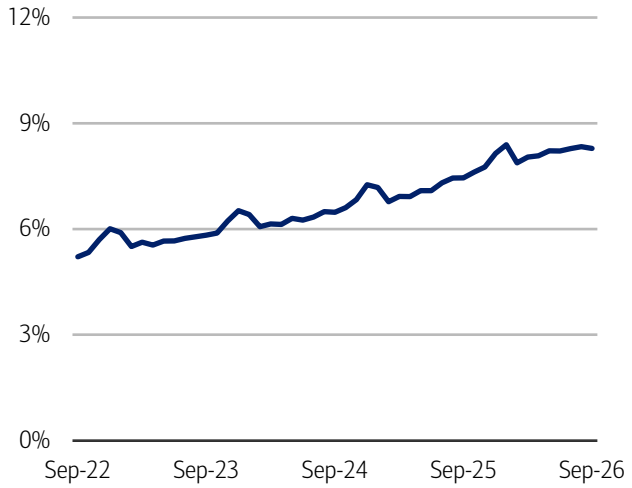
Source: Bank of America internal data
Note: Holiday items include all merchant category codes for which spending in November through December is at least 20% of total annual spending in the category.

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A concern often raised as we move into the holidays is whether consumers will lean on less traditional forms of credit such as buy now, pay later (BNPL) to finance their spending. Frequent BNPL users tend to have higher credit card utilization rates (read more in: Do consumers have wiggle room to absorb higher gas prices?).

Looking at the share of households in Bank of America deposit data with a BNPL payment, we do tend to see a seasonal rise over the holidays (Exhibit 13), though in past years, these increases have quickly reversed. Further, while the underlying trend in BNPL usage is upwards, there are no signs of a sharp acceleration. We do, however, see some evidence that BNPL is being used to finance more expensive purchases, with the share of households making repayments above $500 rising, albeit relatively slowly (Exhibit 14).

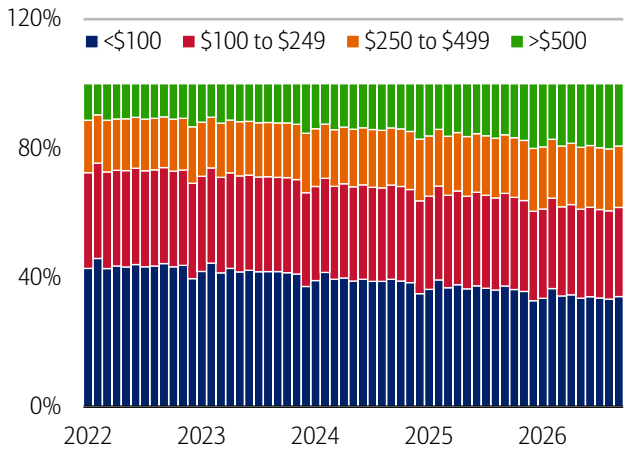
Exhibit 13: 8.3% of Bank of America households had a BNPL payment in September
Share of households with a BNPL payment in the month (monthly, %)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 14: Almost one in five households with BNPL usage has a repayment of over $500
Share of households with BNPL payments by repayment amount (monthly, $ amounts)

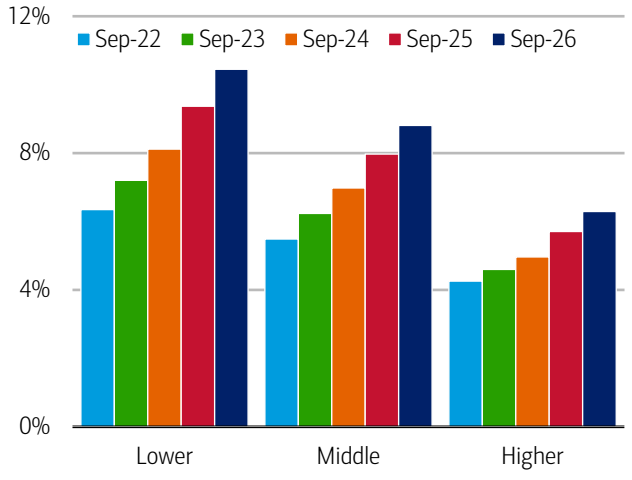


Source: Bank of America internal data

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The tendency towards greater usage is occurring across income cohorts, though is somewhat more pronounced for lower-income households (Exhibit 15). However, higher-income households have the largest share of BNPL payments above $500 (Exhibit 16). Overall, in our view, the increase in the share of BNPL users heading into the season does not appear too concerning, though the rate of usage for some BNPL consumers does bear watching.

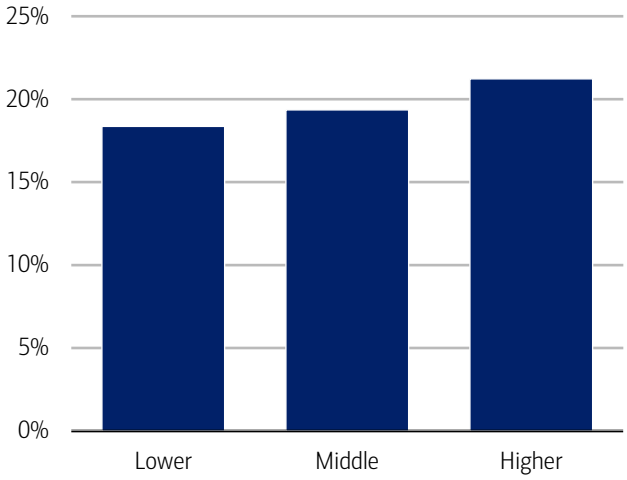
Exhibit 15: Lower-income households have seen larger adoption of BNPL...
Share of households with a BNPL payment in the month by household income tercile (monthly, %)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 16: ....but a larger share of higher-income households have BNPL payments over $500
Share of BNPL payments by spending amount across household income terciles (September 2026, %)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Methodology

Selected Bank of America transaction data is used to inform the macroeconomic views expressed in this report and should be considered in the context of other economic indicators and publicly available information. In certain instances, the data may provide directional and/or predictive value. The data used is not comprehensive; it is based on **aggregated and anonymized** selections of Bank of America data and may reflect a degree of selection bias and limitations on the data available.

Any payments data represents aggregated spend from US Retail, Preferred, Small Business and Wealth Management clients with a deposit account or credit card. Aggregated spend include total credit card, debit card, ACH, wires, bill pay, business/peer-to-peer, cash, and checks.

Any **Small Business** payments data represents aggregate spend from Small Business clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card. Payroll payments data include channels such as ACH (automated clearing house), bill pay, checks and wire. Bank of America per Small Business client data represents activity spending from active Small Business clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card and at least one transaction in each month. Small businesses in this report include business clients within Bank of America and generally defined as under $5mm in annual sales revenue.

Unless otherwise stated, data is not adjusted for seasonality, processing days or portfolio changes, and may be subject to periodic revisions.

The differences between the total and per household card spending growth rate (if discussed) can be explained by the following reasons:

1. Overall total card spending growth is partially boosted by the growth in the number of active cardholders in our sample. This could be due to an increasing customer base or inactive customers using their cards more frequently.
2. Per household card spending growth only looks at households that complete at least five transactions with Bank of America cards in the month. Per household spending growth isolates impacts from a changing sample size, which could be unrelated to underlying economic momentum, and potential spending volatility from less active users.
3. Overall total card spending includes small business card spending while per household card spending does not.
4. Differences due to using processing dates (total card spending) versus transaction date (per household card spending).
5. Other differences including household formations due to young adults moving in and out of their parent's houses during COVID.

Any household consumer deposit data based on Bank of America internal data is derived by anonymizing and aggregating data from Bank of America consumer deposit accounts in the US and analyzing that data at a highly aggregated level. Whenever median household savings and checking balances are quoted, the data is based on a fixed cohort of households that had a consumer deposit account (checking and/or savings account) for all months from January 2019 through the most current month of data shown.

Bank of America aggregated credit/debit card spending per household includes spending from active US households only. Only consumer card holders making a minimum of five transactions a month are included in the dataset. Spending from corporate cards are excluded. Data regarding merchants who receive payments are identified and classified by the Merchant Categorization Code (MCC) defined by financial services companies. The data are mapped using proprietary methods from the MCCs to the North American Industry Classification System (NAICS), which is also used by the Census Bureau, in order to classify spending data by subsector. Spending data may also be classified by other proprietary methods not using MCCs.

Store category aggregation for "more discretionary", "partly discretionary", and "mostly necessity" is defined as follows:

More discretionary: furniture, electronics, building materials, hobbies, miscellaneous stores, nonstore retail, clothing.

Partly discretionary: auto, health and personal care, general merchandise.

Mostly necessity: Gasoline, food and beverage.

We consider a measure of services necessity spending that includes but is not limited to groceries, utilities, and gasoline. Discretionary services includes but is not limited to charitable donations, leisure travel, entertainment, and professional/consumer services. Discretionary retail includes but is not limited to general merchandise, miscellaneous, clothing, electronics and furniture. It excludes categories like groceries and gasoline. Holiday spending is defined as items in which spending in the November-December period is usually at least 20% of total annual spending on the category. Value and premium grocers are determined judgmentally on a proprietary analysis of merchants by equity analysts. The "more discretionary" retail category includes furniture, electronics, building materials, online marketplaces, clothing retailers and miscellaneous stores; while "partly discretionary" retail contains auto parts and services, health and personal care retailers, general merchandise and "mostly necessity" retail contains gas and groceries.

Lower, middle and higher household income cuts in Bank of America credit and debit card spending per household, and consumer deposit account data are based on quantitative estimates of each households' income. These quantitative estimates are bucketed according to terciles, with a third of households placed in each tercile periodically. The lowest tercile represents 'lower income', the middle tercile represents 'middle income' and the highest tercile 'higher income'. The income thresholds between these terciles will move over time, reflecting any number of factors that impact income, including general wage inflation, changes in social security payments and individual households' income. The income and tercile in which a household is categorised are periodically re-assessed.

Generations, if discussed, are defined as follows: Gen Z, born after 1995; Younger Millennials: born between 1989-1995; Older Millennials: born between 1978-1988; Gen Xers: born between 1965-1977; Baby Boomer: 1946-1964; Traditionalists: pre-1946.

Any reference to card spending per household on gasoline includes all purchases at gasoline stations and might include purchases of non-gas items.

Additional information about the methodology used to aggregate the data is available upon request.

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Disclosures

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Economy

The Institute Employment Report: September 2026

07 October 2026

Key takeaways

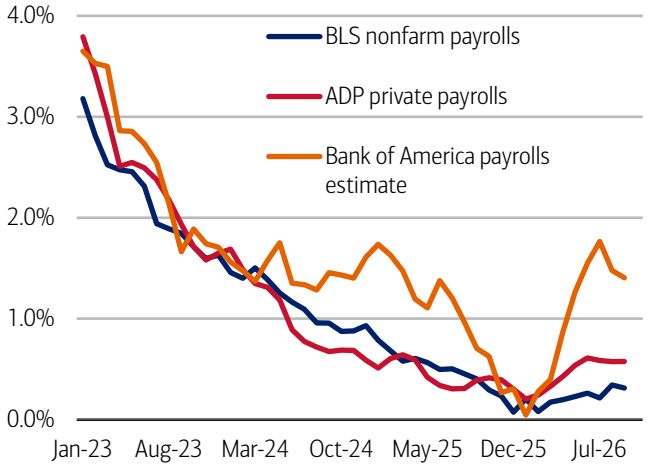
- Job growth softened further in September, according to Bank of America's deposit data, with growth of 1.4% year-over-year (YoY), from 1.5% in August. But falling unemployment payments in September indicate a relatively healthy overall picture.
- Lower-income households' wage growth remains strongest, despite a narrowing gap. After-tax wage growth eased to 4.5% YoY for lower-income households in September, while rising to 3.8% and 3.7% for middle- and higher-income households, respectively.
- Lower tax withholdings and a relative strengthening in the younger/lower-income end of the labor market are driving this story. Additionally, average hours have risen in some lower-paid industries, which is also boosting pay packets.

Job growth slowed in September, but unemployment trends are benign

Our estimate of job growth – which uses Bank of America deposit data to track changes in the number of customer accounts receiving a paycheck (see Methodology) – slowed further in September, to 1.4% year-over-year (YoY) from 1.5% YoY in August. The data can be noisy, partly due to seasonal variation and differences in pay-period timing, but in our view, the latest reading is consistent with the easing in payrolls growth seen in the September Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) data (Exhibit 1).

Still, despite slower hiring, there is little sign of a rise in joblessness in Bank of America data. Unemployment payments into customer accounts showed a YoY decline in September (Exhibit 2). So, overall, labor market trends appear resilient.

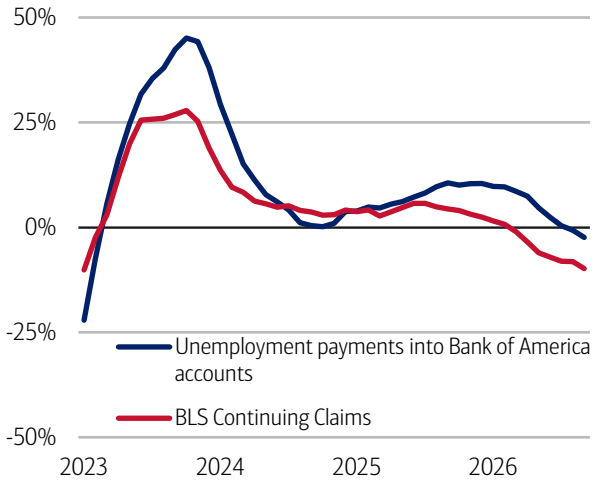
Exhibit 1: September payroll growth showed further slowing in Bank of America deposit account data
Payroll estimates from Bank of America customer deposit account data (three-month moving average, % YoY), the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) and Automatic Data Processing (ADP) (monthly, YoY)



Source: Bank of America internal data, Haver Analytics
Note: BLS and ADP data are seasonally adjusted, Bank of America data is not seasonally adjusted.

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Exhibit 2: Unemployment payments declined YoY in September, according to Bank of America consumer deposit data
Number of households receiving unemployment payments (three-month moving average, YoY%, not seasonally adjusted (NSA)) and BLS Continuing Claims (three-month moving average, YoY%, seasonally adjusted (SA))



Source: Bank of America internal data, Bloomberg

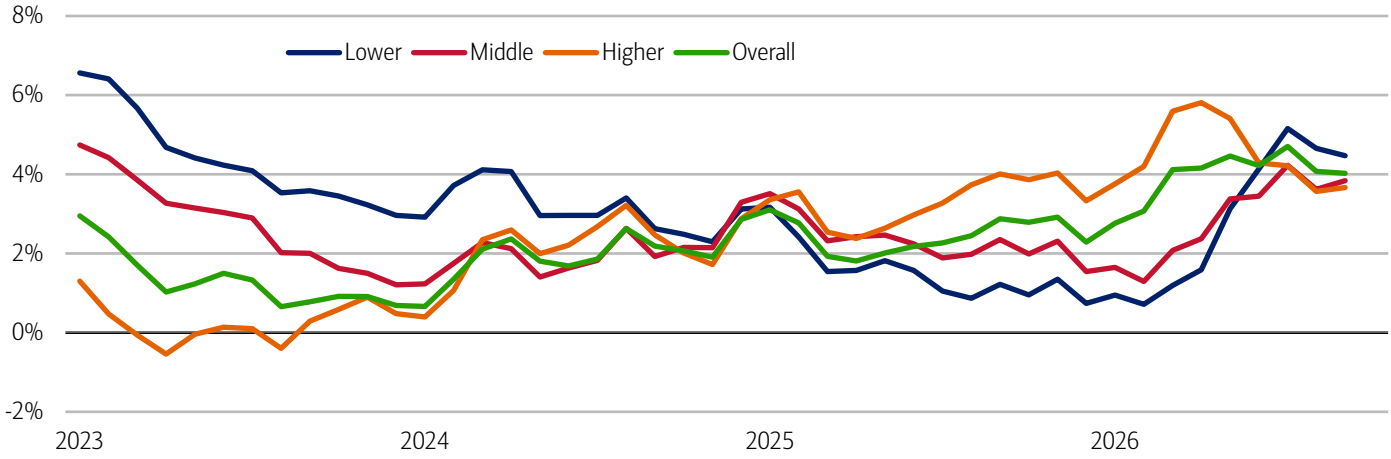
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After-tax wage growth cooled for lower-income, but rose for other cohorts

Lower-income wage growth eased to 4.5% YoY in September from 4.7% YoY in August, while wage growth for middle- and higher-income households rose to 3.8% and 3.7% YoY, respectively. Overall, these changes were modest, and lower-income households are continuing to see faster after-tax wage growth than other cohorts, a notable turnaround from the "K-shaped" pattern we observed over much of 2025 and 2026 (Exhibit 3).

Exhibit 3: Lower-income wage growth remains strongest, despite a narrowing gap

After-tax wage and salary growth by household income terciles, based on Bank of America aggregated consumer deposit account data (three-month moving average, YoY%, SA)



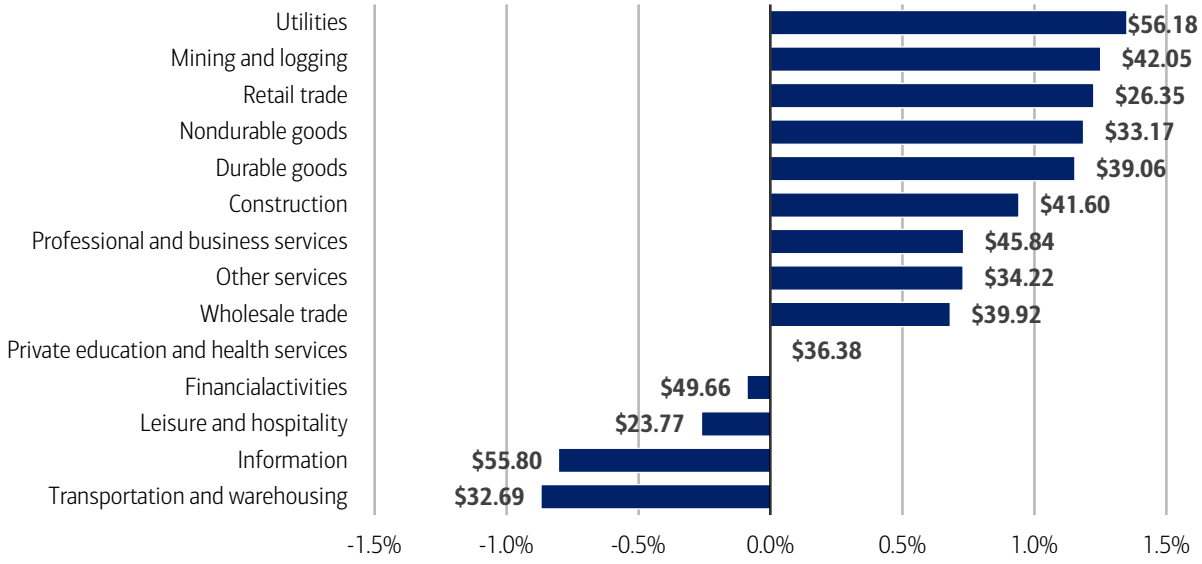
Source: Bank of America internal data

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In our view, the pick-up in lower- and middle-income households' after-tax wage growth continues to reflect the impact of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBA) in reducing tax withholdings, alongside an underlying rise in job-to-job changes at the younger/lower-income end of the labor market (for more, read: The Institute Employment Report: August 2026). Consistent with that underlying pick up, BLS data shows a solid YoY rise in average hours worked in several relatively lower-paid industries, such as manufacturing, retail and other services. Hourly workers in these industries are likely seeing rising paychecks as a result (Exhibit 4).

Exhibit 4: Some relatively lower-paid industries have seen a rise in hours worked

Average weekly hours by industry, July-September 2026 (% YoY) and average hourly earnings by industry, July-September 2026 ($)



Source: Haver Analytics

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Estimate of payroll growth from Bank of America internal data is based on the change in customer accounts receiving a paycheck in the month. An adjustment is made for the difference between overall population growth and customer account growth. Occasionally historic payments can be reclassified, leading to revisions in the series.

An estimate of bonus growth from Bank of America deposit data is calculated by looking at customers who have received an inbound ACH payroll transaction in the last two years. From this sample an estimate of bonuses is derived by looking for payroll transactions which are over 50% higher than the median regular payroll payments received by the customer. Of these payments only those that were received around the same time in each of the last two years are selected.

The job-to-job change rate (j2j rate) is defined as the proportion of customers with an identified change in their employer as a proportion of the total number of customers with employment income. We estimate the median pay rise associated with a j2j change using the pay in the first three months of the new job compared to the same three months a year ago.

Additional information about the methodology used to aggregate the data is available upon request.

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Economy

Entering the age of the older consumer

01 October 2026

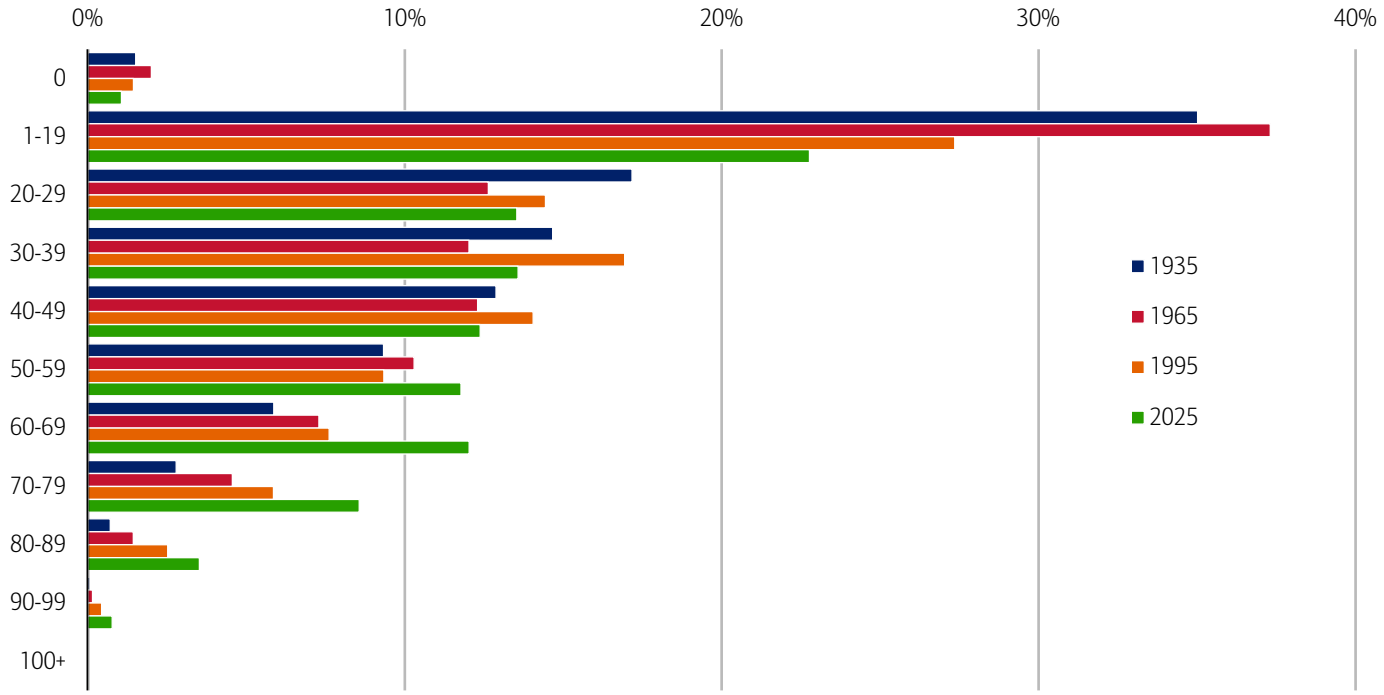
Key takeaways

- The older consumer is moving center stage. America's population has been aging for decades, but the shift has accelerated: the share aged over 60 increased by almost 10 percentage points (pp) between 1995 and 2025. And the Census Bureau projects the share of the population over 60 will rise another 5pp by 2055, to stand at nearly 30% of the population.
- More free time means a different spending mix. People aged 65 and over spend around two and a half fewer hours per day working and roughly two hours more on leisure than the overall adult population. Bank of America data shows that older households allocate relatively more of their card spending to groceries and travel, and less to restaurants, gasoline, general merchandise and clothing.
- Households aged over 55 held close to $140 trillion in net worth in the second quarter of 2026, giving many older consumers considerable capacity to spend on travel and other leisure categories. But wealth is not evenly distributed, and healthcare and other cost pressures remain significant for older households on tighter or fixed incomes.

Population aging is nothing new, but it is accelerating

The US population has been growing relatively "older" for a long time. Exhibit 1 shows that the proportion of the population under 20 years old shrank from the mid-1960s through 2025. At the same time, the proportion of the population in older age groups has been rising.

Exhibit 1: Over time the US population has steadily aged
Proportion of US population by age range (%)



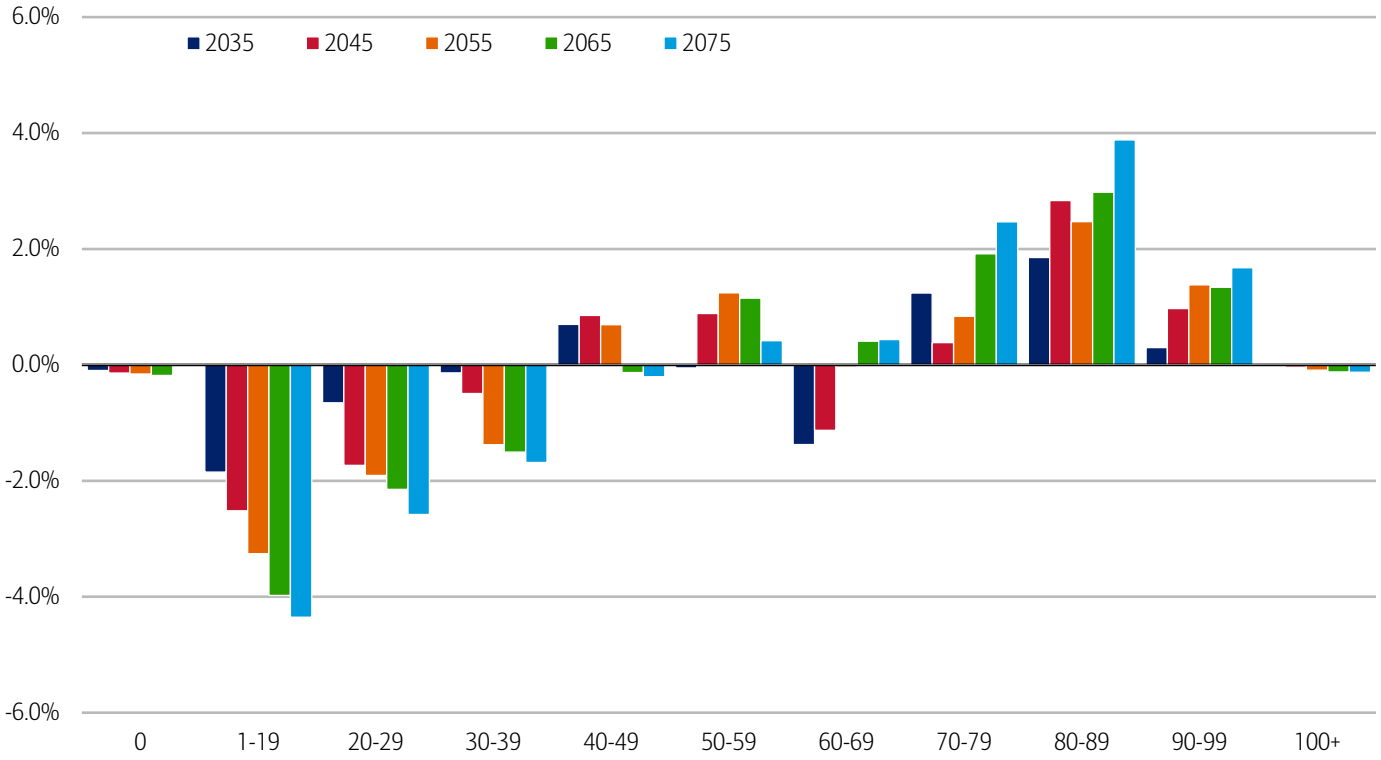
Source: Human Mortality Database; Bank of America Institute calculations

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Additionally, there has been a notable acceleration in the relative aging of the population in recent years. For example, between 1995 and 2025, the proportion of the population aged over 60 rose by almost 10 percentage points (pp) to 25%.

Several factors have driven this. First, fertility rates in the US, as in much of the world, have fallen sharply. This has slowed natural population growth and, by reducing the number of younger people relative to older cohorts, has increased the share of the population at older ages. Second, more recently, net inward migration to the US has slowed. Because migrants tend to be younger than the overall population, weaker immigration also tends to raise the average age. Finally, rising life expectancy over much of the post-war period has allowed more people to survive into older age, further increasing the older population's share.

Exhibit 2: The trend towards an older composition of the population is expected to continue
Forecast changes in the share of population by age group relative to 2025 (pp)



Source: United States Census Bureau

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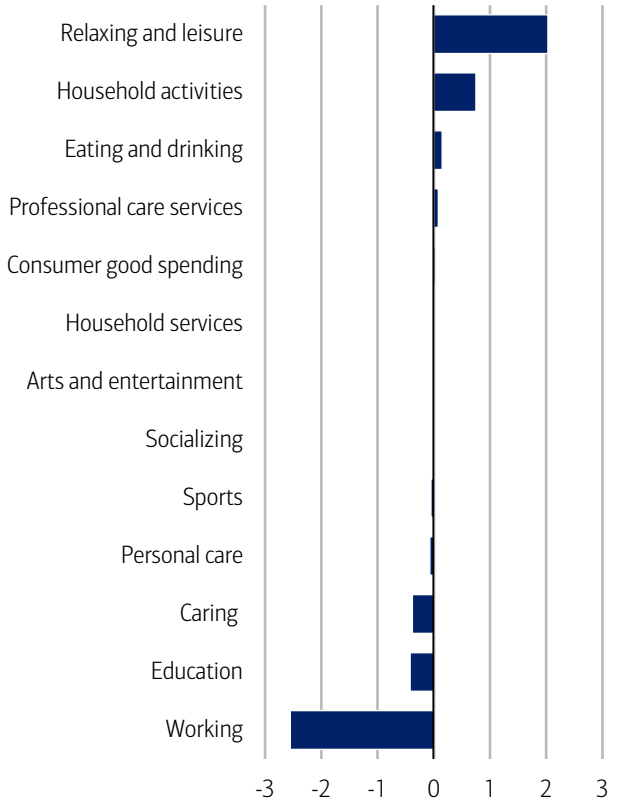
Lower fertility and, more recently, weaker net migration look set to slow overall US population growth in the decades ahead. As a result, older Americans are likely to play an increasingly important role in the economy, both as a share of the population and, in many age groups, in absolute numbers. The Census Bureau projects the share of the population over 60 will rise another 5pp by 2055, to stand at nearly 30% of the population (Exhibit 2). For businesses, understanding how the needs and spending patterns of older consumers differ from those of younger generations will therefore become increasingly relevant.

Older age groups allocate their time differently

Why does this matter? One reason is that older people tend to spend their time and money quite differently from younger adults. Most obviously, many work less or have retired altogether. Data from the American Time Use Survey (ATUS) shows that people aged 65 and over spend, on average, around two and a half fewer hours per day working than the population aged 15+ (Exhibit 3).

That leaves considerably more time for other activities. People aged 65 and over spend around two hours more per day on leisure and sports activities, with television viewing accounting for a particularly large share of this additional leisure time (Exhibit 4).

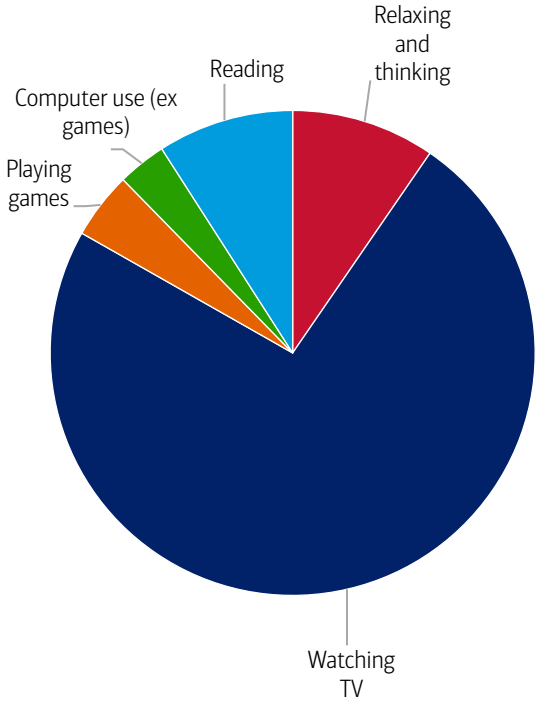
Exhibit 3: Older people spend less time working and more time relaxing
Difference between time spent on activities for those aged over 65 years old compared to all aged over 15 years old (hours)



Source: Haver Analytics (American Time Use Survey)

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Exhibit 4: Watching television is by far the largest relaxation activity
Breakdown of hours spent on selected relaxation and leisure activities for those aged over 65 (hours)



Source: Haver Analytics (American Time Use Survey)

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Older households also spend differently

Bank of America internal data on credit and debit card spending provides insights into how these differences in older generations' use of time also impact their spending. Rather than splitting our spending data by generation, as we often do, here we split by age bands, allowing for consistent comparisons over time.

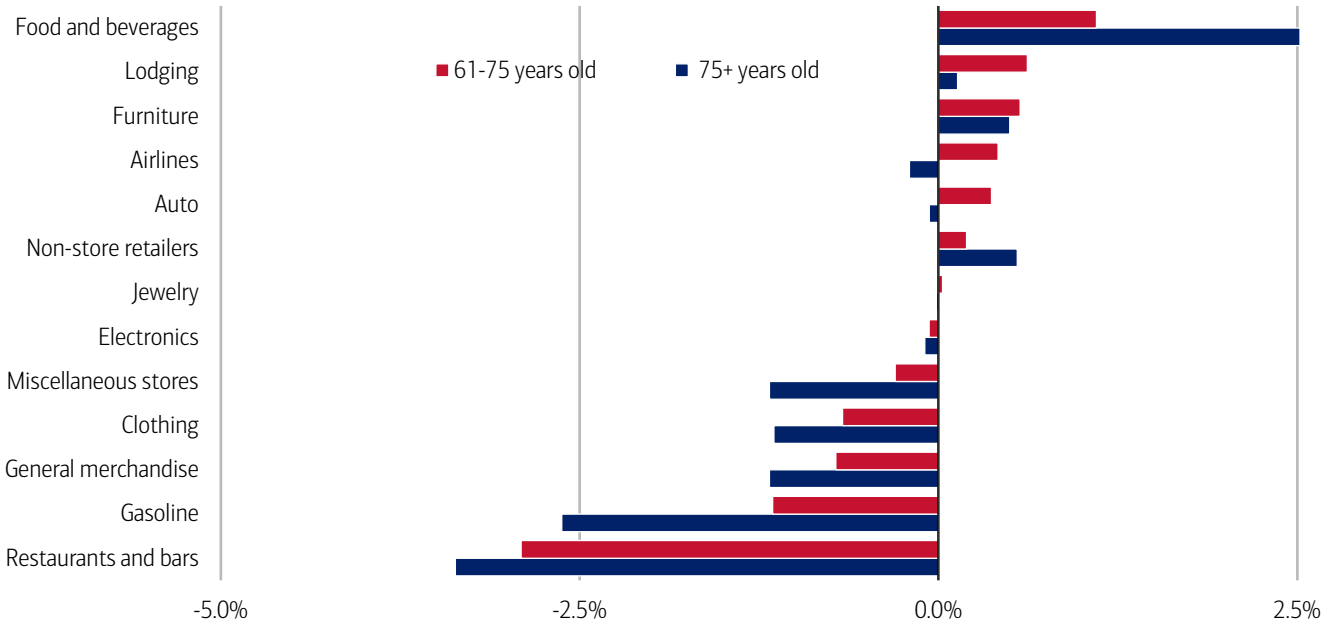
Exhibit 5 shows how the composition of card spending of households aged 61-75 and those older than 75 differs from that of all households. A few things stand out. For one, older households devote a greater share of their overall card spending to groceries (food and beverages). Households aged 61-75 also allocate more spending to travel (airlines and lodging). And restaurants and bars, gasoline, general merchandise and clothing account for a smaller share of older households' card spending.

These differences may seem fairly intuitive. Older households have more leisure hours, so spend relatively more on travel to enjoy them. Previously we found that more available time may support travel particularly around retirement, although the discretionary spending lift can be temporary (for more, read our publication: Paychecks to pensions: The evolution of retiree spending).

Older households are also likely to have less need to update their work wardrobes, so they probably spend less on clothing.

Exhibit 5: Older households allocate more of their card spending to groceries and travel, but less to eating out, gasoline, general merchandise and clothing

Difference in the share of total card spending by households aged 61-75 and 75+ relative to overall households' spending share, by category (January-July 2026, pp)



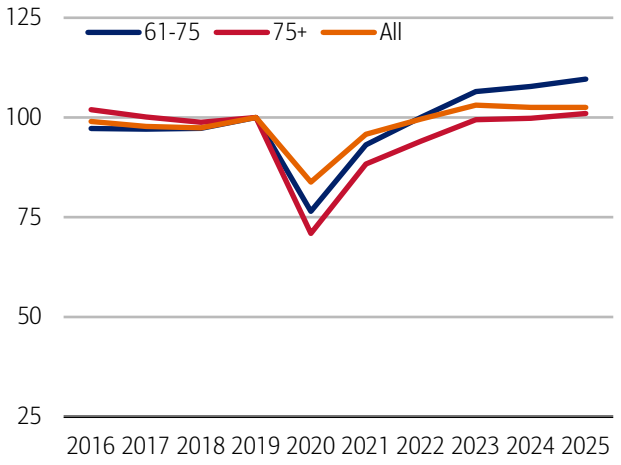
Source: Bank of America internal data

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Still, older households' relatively lower spending on restaurants and bars is a little more curious, perhaps, given dining out could be one way of making use of more leisure time. Indeed, when we look at how these spending shares are evolving, we find a nuanced picture. While households aged 61-75 do spend relatively less on restaurants and bars than the overall population, they appear to be narrowing this gap. But for those older than 75 this is not the case. In our view, the pandemic may still be weighing on dining-out spending among this older age group (Exhibit 6).

Exhibit 6: For restaurants and bars the story is mixed across older cohorts…

Share of households' total card spending on restaurants and bars (annual averages 2016-2025, index 2019 = 100)

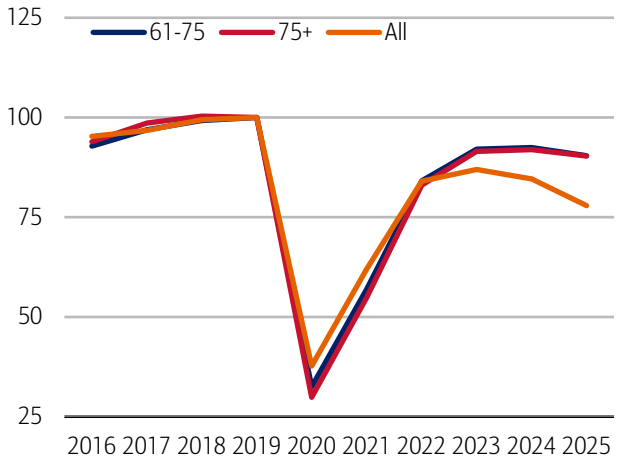


Source: Bank of America internal data

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Exhibit 7: …but they are increasing their spending share relative to the overall population in airlines

Share of households' total card spending on airlines (annual averages 2016-2025, index 2019 = 100)



Source: Bank of America internal data

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Interestingly, however, the airline spending share of both older groups has recovered more strongly since the pandemic than that of all households, although it remains below its 2019 level (Exhibit 7).

Aging presents opportunities, but also challenges

In our view, the aging of the US population presents important opportunities for the economy and businesses. Older consumers have more leisure time and businesses that cater to these demands may therefore benefit.

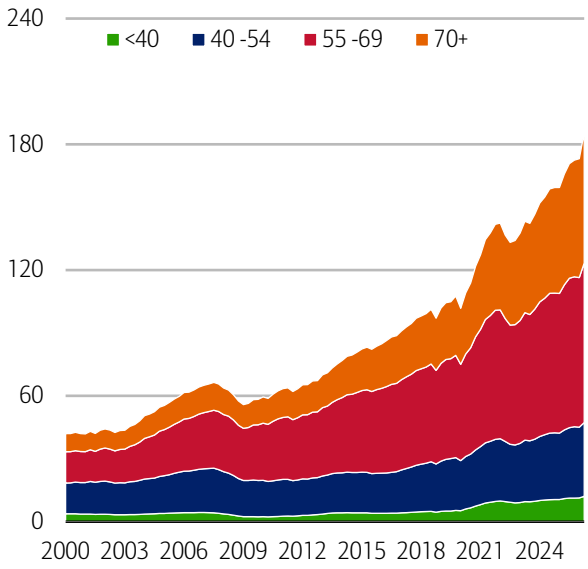
Moreover, some older consumers hold considerable amounts of net wealth and have been some of the biggest beneficiaries of recent rises in equities. Using data from the Federal Reserve, Exhibit 8 shows that as of the second quarter of 2026 the net worth of those households aged 55 and over was close to $140 trillion, around three-quarters of the total. And with equity markets rising strongly, these age groups have seen a more than 20% increase in their net worth over the past two years, potentially enhancing their spending power further.

But an important caveat is that not all older consumers are in this position. Previous Institute work found evidence consistent with equity-market wealth effects being concentrated toward higher-income households (read our publication: Paychecks to pensions: The evolution of retiree spending). And Census Bureau research has found that around 14% of Social Security recipients aged over 65 rely on it for over 90% of their income. For older households without a wealth cushion, recent elevated cost pressures, like gasoline, will likely have put them under more significant financial strain. They will also be more dependent on cost-of-living (COLA) increases in Social Security to underpin their spending.

And, more broadly, outside of card spending, healthcare costs are a much larger factor in older households' budgets (Exhibit 9). The evolution of these costs going forward will be a key variable for older consumers' budgets.

Exhibit 8: A large and growing proportion of net worth is held by older cohorts

Distribution of household wealth by age ($, trillions)

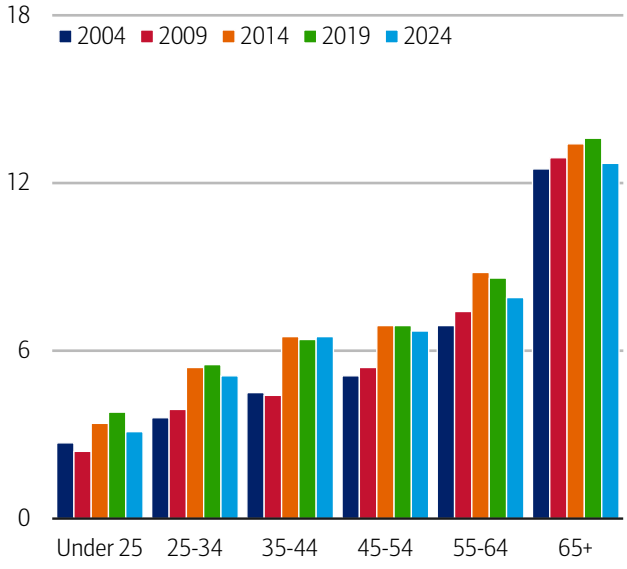


Source: Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System

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Exhibit 9: Healthcare is a significant cost for older households

Healthcare spending as a percentage of overall household expenditure by age groups (%)



Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)

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Methodology

Selected Bank of America transaction data is used to inform the macroeconomic views expressed in this report and should be considered in the context of other economic indicators and publicly available information. In certain instances, the data may provide directional and/or predictive value. The data used is not comprehensive; it is based on **aggregated and anonymized** selections of Bank of America data and may reflect a degree of selection bias and limitations on the data available.

Any payments data represents aggregated spend from US Retail, Preferred, Small Business and Wealth Management clients with a deposit account or credit card. Aggregated spend include total credit card, debit card, ACH, wires, bill pay, business/peer-to-peer, cash, and checks.

Any **Small Business** payments data represents aggregate spend from Small Business clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card. Payroll payments data include channels such as ACH (automated clearing house), bill pay, checks and wire. Bank of America per Small Business client data represents activity spending from active Small Business clients with a deposit account or a Small Business credit card and at least one transaction in each month. Small businesses in this report include business clients within Bank of America and generally defined as under $5mm in annual sales revenue.

Unless otherwise stated, data is not adjusted for seasonality, processing days or portfolio changes, and may be subject to periodic revisions.

The differences between the total and per household card spending growth rate (if discussed) can be explained by the following reasons:

1. Overall total card spending growth is partially boosted by the growth in the number of active cardholders in our sample. This could be due to an increasing customer base or inactive customers using their cards more frequently.
2. Per household card spending growth only looks at households that complete at least five transactions with Bank of America cards in the month. Per household spending growth isolates impacts from a changing sample size, which could be unrelated to underlying economic momentum, and potential spending volatility from less active users.
3. Overall total card spending includes small business card spending while per household card spending does not.
4. Differences due to using processing dates (total card spending) versus transaction date (per household card spending).
5. Other differences including household formations due to young adults moving in and out of their parent's houses during COVID.

Any household consumer deposit data based on Bank of America internal data is derived by anonymizing and aggregating data from Bank of America consumer deposit accounts in the US and analyzing that data at a highly aggregated level. Whenever median household savings and checking balances are quoted, the data is based on a fixed cohort of households that had a consumer deposit account (checking and/or savings account) for all months from January 2019 through the most current month of data shown.

Bank of America aggregated credit/debit card spending per household includes spending from active US households only. Only consumer card holders making a minimum of five transactions a month are included in the dataset. Spending from corporate cards are excluded. Data regarding merchants who receive payments are identified and classified by the Merchant Categorization Code (MCC) defined by financial services companies. The data are mapped using proprietary methods from the MCCs to the North American Industry Classification System (NAICS), which is also used by the Census Bureau, in order to classify spending data by subsector. Spending data may also be classified by other proprietary methods not using MCCs.

We consider a measure of services necessity spending that includes but is not limited to groceries, utilities, and gasoline. Discretionary services includes but is not limited to charitable donations, leisure travel, entertainment, and professional/consumer services. Discretionary retail includes but is not limited to general merchandise, miscellaneous, clothing, electronics and furniture. It excludes categories like groceries and gasoline. Holiday spending is defined as items in which spending in the November-December period is usually at least 20% of total annual spending on the category. Value and premium grocers are determined judgmentally on a proprietary analysis of merchants by equity analysts.

Durables spending is defined as spending on electronics, building materials, auto-related spending and furniture. Premium durables spending is based on a selection of retailers who are judged to sell relatively higher value products. Conversely, value durables spending is based on a selection of retailers who are judged to sell relatively lower value products.

Lower, middle and higher household income cuts in Bank of America credit and debit card spending per household, and consumer deposit account data are based on quantitative estimates of each households' income. These quantitative estimates are bucketed according to terciles, with a third of households placed in each tercile periodically. The lowest tercile represents 'lower income', the middle tercile represents 'middle income' and the highest tercile 'higher income'. The income thresholds between these terciles will move over time, reflecting any number of factors that impact income, including general wage inflation, changes in social security payments and individual households' income. The income and tercile in which a household is categorised are periodically re-assessed.

Generations, if discussed, are defined as follows: Gen Z, born after 1995; Younger Millennials: born between 1989-1995; Older Millennials: born between 1978-1988; Gen Xers: born between 1965-1977; Baby Boomer: 1946-1964; Traditionalists: pre-1946.

Any reference to card spending per household on gasoline includes all purchases at gasoline stations and might include purchases of non-gas items.

Additional information about the methodology used to aggregate the data is available upon request.

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Disclosures

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